ELECTORAL VIOLENCE IN ENGLAND AND WALES, 1832–1914*

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I
INTRODUCTION

Electoral violence should interest modern historians and social scientists. As the political scientist Sarah Birch recently put it, 'Violence is perhaps the worst thing that can happen in an election. Voting is meant to be a tool of democracy — a fair and above all peaceful means of resolving differences. When force intrudes into the electoral process, something has gone profoundly wrong'.[1] In the twenty-first century, violence continues to cast a shadow over many elections in sub-Saharan Africa and South-East Asia, and recently in Belarus and the United States after the declaration of presidential results. Today, the absence of electoral violence (alongside direct bribery) is almost universally recognized as barometric of both the health of a country's democracy and the pluralism of its political culture, and it is a key focus of development studies.[2] According to this view, Britain is usually regarded as a leading light in global democratization, especially in the pivotal long nineteenth century, which saw the gradual dilution of the hegemony of the aristocracy and the birth of the 'mother of parliaments' without violence on the

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[1] Sarah Birch, *Electoral Violence, Corruption, and Political Order* (Princeton, 2020), p. ix.

[2] See S. Birch, U. Daxecker and K. Höglund, 'Electoral Violence: An Introduction', *Journal of Peace Research*, lvii, 1 (2020).

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scale experienced elsewhere. Using a large new dataset and a method which combines machine learning with mass hand-coding, this article reassesses the role of violence in English and Welsh elections in the crucial years between the Great Reform Act of 1832 and the onset of the First World War, arguing that historians have gravely underestimated its frequency. An insensitivity to the scale and diachronic trend of electoral violence has made it easy to view British democratization after 1832 as a largely peaceful and linear process, and this article challenges this still-popular Whiggish view. Second, we contest the popular explanation that electoral disturbances and deaths are best understood as plebeian and cultural in origin, and instead suggest that they were frequently strategically engineered by elites for political utility. This article provides a new perspective on the history of electoral violence in England and Wales and makes a revisionist intervention in the long-running debate about campaign rituals.[3]

Elections in the 1860s, 1870s and 1880s are particularly important democratic milestones because they incorporated a new mass working-class electorate who had been enfranchised by the Second Reform Act of 1867 and the Third Reform Act of 1884. If we measure electoral violence in terms of deaths, riots, disturbances and more minor incidents (see below for our definitions of these terms), the campaign in 1868 featured no fewer than thirty-nine riots, 118 disturbances, 195 incidents and seventeen deaths in England and Wales alone during its thirty-day campaign. The *London Review* described the 'election bloodshed' thus:

> Riots and confusion have reigned in those districts where local party feeling runs high. In Newport, the military had to charge upon the populace, wounding several persons, and killing a woman who was endeavouring to rescue her son. The son has since died. At Tipton the Liberal voters were stoned by the mob and a surgeon was severely cut in the head. A special constable who interfered was left for dead in the streets and his brother was dragged out and beaten with pick handles . . . An election riot took place at Blackburn . . . and a man was killed there. Bolton, Wakefield, Southampton, Limerick, and Galway have all been the scenes of shameful riots. At Bristol, property to the extent of from £12,000 to £15,000 was destroyed, and thirty or forty people injured.[4]

[3] Frank O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies: The Social Meaning of Elections in England, 1780–1860', *Past and Present*, no. 135 (May 1992).

[4] 'The Bloodshed of the Elections', *London Review of Politics, Society, Literature, Arts, and Science*, 21 Nov. 1868, 563–4.

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Such violence was not simply transient political excitement following the Second Reform Act, because it continued into the 1870s and 1880s. Even after the introduction in 1872 of the secret ballot, long touted as a remedy for voter intimidation, our dataset suggests that the two subsequent elections (1874 and 1880) saw sixty-one riots, 143 disturbances, 266 violent incidents, and thirteen deaths between them. The contest in 1880 featured particularly high candidate expenditure, and eighteen newly elected members of parliament were subsequently unseated on petition, primarily on grounds of bribery and treating.[5] This ugly experience ushered in Henry James's uncompromising Corrupt and Illegal Practices Act in 1883, which increased the penalties for bribery, treating and undue influence, and placed strict limits on election expenditure. It was followed in 1884 by the Third Reform Act (which extended the provisions of the Second Reform Act to the counties) and in 1885 by the Redistribution of Seats Act (which occasioned a shift towards arithmetically equal single-member constituencies). Hopes of improved electoral morality ran high as the country went to the polls in November 1885. While the election was (according to the *Times*) 'on the whole pure' on account of a reduction in bribery and treating, hopes that the reforms of 1883–5 would immediately eliminate violence were sorely dashed: England and Wales witnessed at least twenty-seven riots, 117 disturbances and 253 violent incidents, alongside five deaths.[6] The *Saturday Review* provided a graphic, if politically motivated, depiction of the violence:

> The extreme violence of the disturbances which have broken out at elections during the past week is a social danger and a national disgrace. There has been rioting almost all over the country, from Suffolk to Somerset. Gross insults to ladies have been followed by deliberate attempts to murder unpopular candidates. In South Glamorganshire . . . a thousand men wrecked an hotel, injured six policemen, and threatened to smash the ballot boxes. . . . At Melton the Liberal candidate was pursued to the station by a yelling mass of men, who threw sticks, stones, and brickbats at him, and would

[5] William B. Gwyn, *Democracy and the Cost of Politics in Britain* (London, 1962), 51; Kathryn Rix, '"The Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections"? Reassessing the Impact of the 1883 Corrupt Practices Act', *English Historical Review*, cxxiii, 500 (2008), 67.

[6] *Times*, 2 Apr. 1886; Rix, '"Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections"?', 82.

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> probably have killed him if he had not been surrounded by thirty policemen. At Radstock in Somersetshire, the mob . . . attacked the Conservative committee rooms and so completely wrecked the two hotels that, not a single pane of glass was left . . . driving the inmates to the cellars . . . It is a serious matter to call out the soldiers, and a still more serious matter for them to fire at the mob. But anything is preferable to homicidal anarchy.[7]

Given its ubiquity, electoral violence in Britain remains under-studied.[8] This appears to be primarily because historians have underestimated what they have been unable to quantify. It is evidently impossible to read the provincial press, a multi-billion-word corpus, manually for even a single calendar year, making computerized text analysis essential; and electoral

[7] *Saturday Review*, 5 Dec. 1885, 738–9.

[8] Dedicated scholarship on electoral violence includes K. Theodore Hoppen, 'Grammars of Electoral Violence in Nineteenth-Century England and Ireland', *English Historical Review*, cix, 432 (1994); Justin Wasserman and Edwin Jaggard, 'Electoral Violence in Mid Nineteenth-Century England and Wales', *Historical Research*, lxxx, 207 (2007); Donald Richter, 'The Role of Mob Riot in Victorian Elections, 1865–1885', *Victorian Studies*, xv, 1 (1971). The most extensive general account of 'corrupt practice' is Cornelius O'Leary, *The Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections, 1868–1911* (Oxford, 1962). Both O'Leary and Rix ('"Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections"?') are, however, primarily concerned with bribery and treating rather than violence. The following contain some general reflections, but are more concerned with examining violence in the context of parliamentary reform campaigns than at elections: Norman Gash, *Politics in the Age of Peel: A Study in the Technique of Parliamentary Representation, 1830–1850* (London, 1953), chs. 5–7; H. J. Hanham, *Elections and Party Management: Politics in the Time of Disraeli and Gladstone* (London, 1959), chs. 12–13; Charles Seymour, *Electoral Reform in England and Wales: The Development and Operation of the Parliamentary Franchise, 1832–1885* (London, 1915), chs. 12–14. Works explicitly about popular disturbance in the long nineteenth century see electoral violence as a relatively minor facet of a broader history of popular disturbance and protest: see, notably, Donald C. Richter, *Riotous Victorians* (Athens, OH, 1981); John Stevenson, *Popular Disturbances in England, 1700–1832* (London, 1992); Adrian Randall, *Riotous Assemblies: Popular Protest in Hanoverian England* (Oxford, 2006). The final and most recent stream of relevant historiography is focused on the social and cultural meaning of acts of electoral violence and disruption: see especially Jon Lawrence, *Speaking for the People: Party, Language and Popular Politics in England, 1867–1914* (Cambridge, 1998); James Vernon, *Politics and the People: A Study of English Political Culture, c.1815–1867* (Cambridge, 1993); Katrina Navickas, *Protest and the Politics of Space and Place, 1789–1848* (Manchester, 2017); Marc Baer, *The Rise and Fall of Radical Westminster, 1780–1890* (New York, 2012).

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historians have generally steered well clear of such methodologies.[9] Previous quantification attempts have relied on counts of incidents of violence from selected samples of the press, an approach which has unsurprisingly produced substantial underestimations. For example, Cornelius O'Leary counted ten riots in 1874, whereas we find twenty-six.[10] Donald Richter's dedicated studies of 1971 and 1981 find 'no recorded fatalities' nationally during the years 1865–85, whereas we uncover (for England and Wales alone) at least thirty-nine. Richter finds just seventy-one separate incidents of serious disorder in this period, whereas we find at least 599 riots or disturbances (alongside a further 812 isolated incidents).[11] Justin Wasserman and Edwin Jaggard's article of 2007, the most extensive analysis published to date, still uncovers only 181 riots, disturbances and incidents at elections between 1857 and 1880 compared to our aggregate of 1,134 for the same period, alongside eleven deaths to our forty-one.[12] Perhaps more significantly, their survey finds that only 13.4 per cent of constituencies in this period experienced one or more violent episodes per election campaign, whereas we find approximately triple this proportion: 38.5 per cent. Other historians have not attempted formal counts, but even the minority who note the stubborn persistence of violence after the Ballot Act 1872 still tend to see it, alongside bribery, as but a waning aspect of the fast-disappearing old 'grubby' world of popular politics.[13] On the contrary, this article argues that violence was endemic in nineteenth-century elections after 1832. On this basis, it is wholly inadequate to treat violence (and bribery) as inexorably declining on account of legislative action and changing political and civic morality. Crucially, the statistics and anecdotes already cited are not taken from decades immediately

[9] See Luke Blaxill, *The War of Words: The Language of British Elections, 1880–1914* (Woodbridge, 2020), 21–6.

[10] O'Leary, *Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections*, 88.

[11] Richter, *Riotous Victorians*, 67.

[12] Wasserman and Jaggard, 'Electoral Violence in Mid Nineteenth-Century England and Wales', 129.

[13] See Hoppen, 'Grammars of Electoral Violence in Nineteenth-Century England and Ireland', 610; Seymour, *Electoral Reform in England and Wales*, 432–6; John Garrard, *Democratization in Britain: Elites, Civil Society, and Reform since 1800* (Basingstoke, 2002), 106.

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following the 1832 Reform Act, when many localities retained substantial residual aspects of the famously carnivalesque, venal and ritualized old world of Georgian electoral culture.[14] Instead, they apply to precisely the period when Britain, as it ascended to the height of its industrial, commercial and imperial might, had established a mass franchise and organized party system with significant participatory opportunities for the working class.[15]

This article's findings, especially our discovery of a sharp increase in violence between the Second and Third Reform Acts, have important implications for two important streams of historiography. The first, and more influential, is the so-called 'new political history' which appeared in the 1990s. Influenced by the post-structuralist 'linguistic turn' and 'history from below', these historians shifted focus away from parliament and towards grassroots localities, and from deeds and acts to language.[16] Three authors are particularly important to our discussion of electoral violence: Frank O'Gorman, James Vernon and Jon Lawrence. This trio have studied elections in cultural terms, viewing what happened in them (to varying extents) as rituals, with electoral violence a key ritualistic element of this. Rituals can be broadly defined as repeated and symbolic rule-governed activities, and examples from elections in this period include candidate chairings, processions, nomination days, political dinners, hustings, the canvass, public meetings and speeches.[17] In *Past and Present* in 1992, O'Gorman argued that understanding campaign rituals was essential to understanding elections themselves from the

[14] See Gash, *Politics in the Age of Peel*, chs. 6–7; O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies'.

[15] For the rise of political parties at the grassroots through clubs, associations and societies in the wake of the Second Reform Act, see Hanham, *Elections and Party Management*, especially chs. 5–7.

[16] The development of the critique of 'high politics' (and the related, but quite separate, 'electoral sociology' school preoccupied with social class) in this decade is outlined with admirable clarity in Jon Lawrence, 'Political History', in Stefan Berger, Heiko Feldner and Kevin Passmore (eds.), *Writing History: Theory and Practice* (London, 2003).

[17] See Steven Lukes, 'Political Ritual and Social Integration', in Steven Lukes, *Essays in Social Theory* (London, 1977), 54. For a conceptual discussion, see Frank O'Gorman, 'Ritual Aspects of Popular Politics in England (*c.*1700–1830)', *Memoria y Civilización*, iii (2000), 162–8.

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1780s to the 1860s.[18] For O'Gorman, campaign rituals could be infused, by both elites and people, with political meanings. Subsequent historians, especially Vernon in 1993 and more recently Marc Baer, used this conception of ritual to study political culture 'from below' through the eyes of the people.[19] While O'Gorman and Vernon stressed the disorderly and rumbustious nature of many electoral rituals (and their proclivity to become violent), both also made two important empirical claims about their general nature. First, that political elites were keen to subdue violence and prevent rituals from spiraling out of control: in O'Gorman's words, they were 'desperately anxious to maintain peace and civil order throughout the campaign'.[20] Second, that disorder and violence began to disappear, along with most Hanoverian rituals, in the decades following the Great Reform Act: a process that was largely complete by the mid 1860s, when the modern party system dawned and placed increased organizational power in the hands of elites.[21] This process effectively created a new set of rituals focused on organized campaign events and political meetings which could be closely controlled. Vernon argued that this taming of elections represented a form of 'closure' by which increasingly organized political parties shut out the people, and the disorder that could be used by the voteless as a tool of political expression, from this newly sanitized system.[22] This article's evidence of a marked increase in violence from exactly the time O'Gorman and Vernon argue that it had all but died out challenges this seminal claim. We also argue that elite involvement in electoral violence was likelier to concern its orchestration than its suppression.

[18] See O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies'.

[19] Vernon, *Politics and the People*, 182, 227–9, 248–9, 337–8; Baer, *Rise and Fall of Radical Westminster*. Navickas, *Protest and the Politics of Space and Place*, also uses ritual, but to study popular protests rather than elections. See also Leonard Baker, 'Spaces, Places, Custom and Protest in Rural Somerset and Dorset, *c.* 1780–1867' (University of Bristol Ph.D. thesis, 2020).

[20] O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies', 103–4.

[21] *Ibid.*, 114–115; Vernon, *Politics and the People*, 229–30; Baer, *Rise and Fall of Radical Westminster*, 116–27, 253–4. See also Hoppen, 'Grammars of Electoral Violence in Nineteenth-Century England and Ireland'.

[22] Vernon, *Politics and the People*, 182, 227–9, 248–9, 337–8.

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Lawrence offers a different cultural account, stressing continuities over a much longer period, arguing that elections were not tamed by the 'triumph of party' after 1867, and that new rituals such as public meetings were born alongside the persistence of violence into the Edwardian era.[23] His central observation is that violence remained a politically viable and culturally expected part of electoral behaviour ritual through to 1918, when female enfranchisement and a public mind scarred by the brutality of the First World War swiftly delegitimized it (along with public violence in general).[24] For Lawrence, ritual electoral violence did not persist simply because of enduring cultural venality, but because local party elites often connived in its orchestration, which they regarded, on some level, as a demonstration of the robust health of the polity.[25] By conniving, they willingly sacrificed a degree of control over the political process: an ambiguity embodied by their dogged determination to hold their own public platforms even in the face of opposition disruption and violence.[26] Lawrence clearly regards this important qualitative point of the endurance of electoral violence as more historically salient than he does election-by-election trends. Nevertheless, when he does discuss those long-term patterns, he presents a continuity picture because, at the critical elections when he considers whether the prevalence of violence might have changed, he judges that such changes were small. For example, he doubts that election violence became more disorderly after 1867, or that it reduced markedly in the 1880s, while estimating that levels in January 1910 were likely similar to what they were in the 1880s.[27] Overall, our analysis corroborates Lawrence's broad thesis on the endurance of electoral violence after 1867, and also on the persistence of elite strategizing. However, we qualify his picture in two ways. First, we contend that quantifying both long-term and election-by-election trends in detail is crucial to understanding electoral violence overall.

[23] Lawrence, *Speaking for the People*, 181–4.

[24] Jon Lawrence, 'The Transformation of British Public Politics after the First World War', *Past and Present*, no. 190 (Feb. 2006), 203–12.

[25] Jon Lawrence, *Electing our Masters: The Hustings in British Politics from Hogarth to Blair* (Oxford, 2009), 13–15.

[26] Lawrence, *Speaking for the People*, 164, 181–4.

[27] Lawrence, *Electing our Masters*, 43–4.

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Second, we show that rates of violence in fact changed markedly throughout the period, increasing between the Second and Third Reform Acts rather than simply persisting; and sharply and permanently receding from the Home Rule Crisis election of 1886 onward (barring a modest bounce in January 1910).

The second stream of scholarship is the older, but is influential across disciplines. This 'high political' school of the late 1960s and 1970s places negligible emphasis on disorder (either as an agent of change or as an article of influence) in late nineteenth-century British politics compared to the actions and strategizing of parliamentary elites.[28] These studies have traditionally regarded the 1860s, 1870s and 1880s as a period of relative calm following the fading of the earlier tumults of Chartism, class antagonism and industrial strife.[29] They rarely dwelt on political violence, with the main casualties even of the high-profile Hyde Park reform riots of July 1866 being (in Gertrude Himmelfarb's oft-quoted words) merely 'broken railings and trampled flower beds'.[30] While the proponents of high politics have seen their influence in British political history wane following widespread critique, they continue to exert significant influence in comparative political development studies, where prominent accounts stress British exceptionalism compared to her European peers throughout the long nineteenth century. These accounts emphasize a steady, peaceable and gradualist path towards universal suffrage and non-violent politics.[31] While this article's argument that historians have underestimated the quantity of electoral violence in the long nineteenth century

[28] Maurice Cowling, *1867: Disraeli, Gladstone and Revolution. The Passing of the Second Reform Bill* (Cambridge, 1967). See also A. B. Cooke and John Vincent, *The Governing Passion: Cabinet Government and Party Politics in Britain, 1885–1886* (Brighton, 1974); Andrew Jones, *The Politics of Reform, 1884* (Cambridge, 1972).

[29] W. L. Burn, *The Age of Equipoise: A Study of the Mid-Victorian Generation* (London, 1964).

[30] Gertrude Himmelfarb, 'The Politics of Democracy: The English Reform Act of 1867', *Journal of British Studies*, vi, 1 (1966), 106.

[31] See especially Barrington Moore, *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy: Lord and Peasant in the Making of the Modern World* (Boston, 1993), 33–9. Other works subscribing to a similar view of British exceptionalism include F. H. Herrick, 'The Second Reform Movement in Britain, 1850–1865', *Journal of the History of Ideas*, ix, 2 (1948); Robert A. Dahl, *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition* (New Haven, 1971).

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in general — and during 1868–85 in particular — represents a prima facie challenge to these accounts, our more important claim concerns trajectory. Simply put, we dispute the view that Victorian elections became more peaceful as they became more democratic and as political parties became stronger and better organized. From the perspective of electoral violence, the democratization of Britain in the age of reform was neither incremental nor linear, with the Second Reform Act gravely injuring, rather than abetting, the transition to peaceful electoral politics.

It follows, then, that our first argument, outlined in section III, concerns trends. It is no mean methodological challenge to infer the temporal fluctuations in electoral violence using a multibillion-word corpus. The first difficulty is that incidents are exceptionally challenging to find. As this study resoundingly confirms, even red-letter events such as full-scale riots involving military intervention, and deaths, could be tucked away in unassuming columns of local newspapers and easily escape the attention of historians. The second problem is that, even when found, violence is hard to count meaningfully. Where incidents need to be classified, this must sensitively reflect their severity, press bias must be accounted for, and the tendency of nearby newspapers to recycle stories must be factored in to prevent double-counting. This study meets this challenge by adopting a three-stage process in which sources are retrieved via a computer-assisted search strategy, analysed by a trained team of sixty-two research assistants, and the results manually and computationally cleaned. A clear pattern of electoral violence emerges, sustained even at a regional level, which challenges the general view of peaceful British democratization in the mid nineteenth century held by high political historians and scholars in development studies, and, in various ways, the readings of the subsequent generation of revisionists.

This article's second argument, outlined in section IV, explains electoral violence politically: as something which in large part can be understood as a product of elite strategizing. The present 'cultural' accounts, primarily interested in the important theoretical question of how and how far electoral disorder and violence were parts of contemporary cultural mindsets in various periods, offer little in the way of general models

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or explanations for why violence occurred, or for trends in its occurrence. Two reasons were generally offered by Victorian commentators. The first was violence as a plebeian social pathology: what Richter describes as 'simple love of disorder', Norman Gash as a reflection of the 'indecent public manners of the age', and K. T. Hoppen as symptomatic of venality and boredom, and as a reaction to the granting or withholding of drinks, treats and bribes.[32] The second was violence as something politically utilitarian: that political elites (namely, candidates and agents) strategically employed 'roughs' to help their side secure victory by intimidating electors, preventing voting, forcing voting in a particular way, disrupting meetings, sabotaging buildings and destroying campaigning resources. These two explanations are not necessarily exclusive of each other, and elite strategy could utilize ritual elements. Nevertheless, while Lawrence recognizes the role of elite orchestration, the emphasis of other recent cultural accounts has been of organizers seeking to avoid instigating (and proactively quelling) violence because its occurrence demonstrated their lack of control over plebeian popular politics and passions.[33] Section IV demonstrates that more severe violent incidents, such as riots, can be convincingly explained as elite stratagems where violence was used as a tool by candidates and their agents. Central to this argument is the neglected figure of the hired rough: the *sui generis* embodiment of strategic election violence. We argue that roughs were a ubiquitous staple of electoral politics until 1885, and that they tended to feature in the more strategically beneficial psephological contexts, and where party organization was likely to be strongest. Taking evidence from sections III and IV together, we thus argue that, after the first generation of high political historians overlooked electoral violence in general, the succeeding generation of revisionist cultural accounts paid too little attention to the political explanation: that violence was a tool used by elites to help win elections. In

[32] Richter, 'Role of Mob Riot in Victorian Elections, 1865–1885', 25–6; Gash, *Politics in the Age of Peel*, 152; Hoppen, 'Grammars of Electoral Violence in Nineteenth-Century England and Ireland', 606; Wasserman and Jaggard, 'Electoral Violence in Mid Nineteenth-Century England and Wales', 127–30.

[33] See O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies', 103–4; Vernon, *Politics and the People*, 229.

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making this argument for the importance of politics, we suggest that approaches adapted from modern political science which analyse contemporary electoral violence as a strategic tool have much to offer historians.[34] In turn, we also suggest that its systematic historical analysis in a case such as Britain can benefit scholars seeking to understand, and ultimately mitigate, electoral violence in some new democracies today.[35]

II
METHOD

This project has developed a methodology for capturing and measuring electoral violence across the long nineteenth century in England and Wales. The project omits Scotland and Ireland because of costs, and because Ireland is almost certainly an outlier in electoral violence (with a considerably higher frequency of major incidents and deaths).[36]

Our source base is primarily newspaper reports from the digitized English and Welsh provincial press accessed from the British Newspaper Archive (BNA). We also coded all relevant parliamentary commission and royal commission reports (for example, the 1869 Hartington Commission on election procedures). Our method was to search the entire BNA during general election campaigns (defined as the one-month period closely corresponding to polling) between 1832 and 1910 using machine learning for initial retrieval of articles likely to contain references to electoral violence. The BNA's coverage will never

[34] For a recent literature review on the causes and consequences of contemporary election violence, see Birch, Daxecker and Höglund, 'Election Violence'.

[35] On the value of historical research for our contemporary understanding of political development and democratization, see Giovanni Capoccia and Daniel Ziblatt, 'The Historical Turn in Democratization Studies: A New Research Agenda for Europe and Beyond', *Comparative Political Studies*, xliii, 8–9 (2010). For research drawing valuable contemporary lessons from nineteenth-century electoral history, see, for example, Isabela Mares, *From Open Secrets to Secret Voting: Democratic Electoral Reforms and Voter Autonomy* (Cambridge, 2015); Isabela Mares, *Protecting the Ballot: How First-Wave Democracies Ended Electoral Corruption* (Princeton, 2022); Daniel Ziblatt, 'Shaping Democratic Practice and the Causes of Electoral Fraud: The Case of Nineteenth-Century Germany', *American Political Science Review*, ciii, 1 (2009).

[36] See Hoppen, 'Grammars of Electoral Violence in Nineteenth-Century England and Ireland', 610.

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be exhaustive but is very extensive and contains wide coverage from all regions of England and Wales. In total, we consulted 1,346,488 articles, containing an estimated 2,115,316,571 words, spanning 1,081 newspaper titles. While computerized classification was essential for this initial reconnaissance and retrieval, we decided that, quite apart from the suboptimal quality of the BNA's textual digitization, violence was too complex, varied and multifaceted a topic to classify satisfactorily using computational methods.[37] Our team of trained and supervised research assistants therefore manually read and coded the 19,867 newspaper articles retrieved.[38]

An essential starting point was to define electoral violence. Victorian law classed it as a subset of wider 'electoral corruption', which included bribery and treating, rather than separating it as a stand-alone category. For instance, the Corrupt Practices Act of 1854 defined it as an aspect of 'undue influence', namely, '(1) Any force, violence, restraint or threat thereof; (2) Any injury, damage, harm or loss inflicted, or threat thereof, or other intimidation; (3) Any abduction, duress, or any fraudulent device or contrivance which might impede the proper enjoyment of the franchise'. Drawing upon this, as well as contemporary political-science and historiographical literature, our definition of electoral violence is 'Physical damage, or the explicit and immediate threat of it, to persons and/or property that directly results from the local and national electoral cycle'. We judged each event according to this definition. We encountered many types of violence (whether threatened or actual) including mass disturbances, physical assault or the explicit threat of it, kidnapping of voters, vandalism, destruction of property, theft of property and dueling. Accordingly, we also coded for other variables, for example whether the violence occurred indoors or outdoors, at a political meeting or outside one, to which party (if any) did the perpetrators and/or targets belong, and whether hired roughs were involved. We also used the following general typology, adapted from Wasserman and

[37] See Gidon Cohen, Gary Hutchison and Patrick M. Kuhn, 'DRESS: An Algorithm to Explore Remotely Stored Digital Text Archives', unpubd working paper (2023).

[38] The full coding criteria used by research assistants are available from the authors.

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Jaggard's definition so as to encompass the broadest range of violence across 1832–1914 by including a separate 'individual' category which covers non-mass violence. We accept that scholarly judgement was used to code the plethora of heterogeneous violent events, but point out that very few of our arguments rely on the distinction made between different types of violent event. We include these primarily to enable our findings to be compared against those of other authors.

Riot: A serious and sustained outbreak of collective violence involving the implicit or explicit use of force, intimidation or coercion which resulted in physical damage to persons or property.

Disturbance: A less serious breach of the peace than a riot, involving episodic outbursts of crowd violence rather than sustained disorder.

Incident: A noisy or demonstrative action by a crowd that is caused by, interferes with, or disrupts, an election campaign.

Individual: A violent action or set of actions involving fewer than three to four people, without crowd presence or active involvement.

Given the size of the corpus, this project could not have been attempted without computational search retrieval, and categorization. As such, it is part of what might tentatively be described as an emerging wave of historical analyses in the age of 'big data'.[39] Quantitative analyses in social, cultural and political history involving classification inevitably cause controversy, and arguments against their general use are well rehearsed. The dramatic fall of cliometrics and the first wave of quantitative history since Lawrence Stone's famous critique in this journal in 1979 will not be reprised here, save to acknowledge two of the most direct impacts on our work.[40]

[39] For recent discussion on historians and 'big data', see especially the Alan Turing Institute's Living with Machines project: Ruth Ahnert *et al.*, *Collaborative Historical Research in the Age of Big Data: Lessons from an Interdisciplinary Project* (Cambridge, 2023). See also Luke Blaxill, 'Why Do Historians Ignore Digital Analysis? Bring on the Luddites', *Political Quarterly*, xciv, 2 (2023).

[40] Lawrence Stone, 'The Revival of Narrative: Reflections on a New Old History', *Past and Present*, no. 85 (Nov. 1979).

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First, we accept that some of the first wave of quantitative history in the 1960s and 1970s has been effectively critiqued for applying reductive models to sparse datasets which were often coded in ways that were inscrutable to most historians.[41] Our approach builds on the more careful quantitative and mixed-method approaches developed by historians in the years that followed, particularly micro-exemplary methods from demography and related developments in source-based prosopography.[42] The process we employed was to create a quantitative dataset beginning from the contextual understanding of particular sources and cases, building frameworks and coding schemes that speak to theoretical debates while remaining close to the language of the time. An important feature of our final dataset is that it can be read both quantitatively and qualitatively, with links from the coding to the specific sources. Human scholarly judgement was indispensable, and we employed hand-coding using a large supervised team of research assistants. Second, we are mindful that we are not preaching to the converted and that analyses of this kind need to clear a high bar of methodological scrutiny.[43] With that in mind, we have performed five additional analyses to demonstrate the robustness of our findings. These relate to press bias; variation in the volume of news reporting throughout the period; avoiding double-counting of the same unique violent events; the growing unacceptability of violence after 1867; and separating election violence from 'violence as usual'. We include these, as well as an accompanying figure and table, in the Appendix.

[41] For an overview of the critique, with explicit examples, see A. W. Carus and Sheilagh Ogilvie, 'Turning Qualitative into Quantitative Evidence: A Well-Used Method Made Explicit', *Economic History Review*, lxii, 4 (2009).

[42] *Ibid.*; Gidon Cohen, 'Missing, Biased and Unrepresentative: The Quantitative Analysis of Multisource Biographical Data', *Historical Methods: Journal of Quantitative and Interdisciplinary History*, xxxv, 4 (2002).

[43] See, for example, Stone, 'Revival of Narrative: Reflections on a New Old History'; Nancy Fitch, 'Statistical Fantasies and Historical Facts: History in Crisis and its Methodological Implications', *Historical Methods*, xvii, 4 (1984); G. R. Elton, 'Two Kinds of History', in Robert William Fogel and G. R. Elton (eds.), *Which Road to the Past? Two Views of History* (New Haven, 1983). For a recent critique, see Nan Z. Da, 'The Computational Case against Computational Literary Studies', *Critical Inquiry*, xlv, 3 (2019).

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III
TRENDS IN ELECTORAL VIOLENCE

There were 7,154 constituency elections (excluding by-elections) in England and Wales between 1832 and 1910. Of these, 1,778 experienced at least one reported incident of electoral violence, at the locations shown in the Map 1 (throughout the text, when we discuss measures of election violence, we mean reported election violence). As many as 1,369 experienced election violence which occurred before or during polling. The remaining 409 experienced only election violence which occurred after polling, which we argue below is less likely to have been strategically directed at affecting electoral outcomes. As mentioned, Wasserman and Jaggard's study of 2007 is the most sophisticated existing analysis, and it covers the years 1857–80, which was subsequently backdated to 1832 by Christopher Kam in 2010.[44] In Figure 1, we compare this measure (labelled Wasserman–Jaggard–Kam) to the equivalent from our Causes and Consequences project. Figure 2 then shows the Causes and Consequences data broken down by the type of election violence in terms of the proportion of constituency elections experiencing at least one incident.

Figure 1 clearly demonstrates the degree to which previous quantifications have underestimated the extent of election violence. Even the highest Wasserman–Jaggard–Kam reading (for the 1868 election) is roughly on par with the two lowest Causes and Consequences readings (for 1900 and December 1910). Indeed, our analysis suggests that 92.7 per cent of constituencies featured electoral violence at some point during the 1832–80 period and 66.2 per cent in the period 1885–1910. Separate figures are given pre- and post-1885 owing to the extensive boundary changes of that year. There is then the trendline itself, which strongly suggests that historians have misunderstood the trajectory of the evolution of electoral violence as well as underestimating its extent. Significantly, during the decades following the Great Reform Act, when electoral politics was still more like the rumbustious and carnivalesque unreformed Georgian

[44] Wasserman and Jaggard, 'Electoral Violence in Mid Nineteenth-Century England and Wales'; Christopher Kam, 'Violence and Corruption at Nineteenth-Century British Elections', unpubd working paper (2010).

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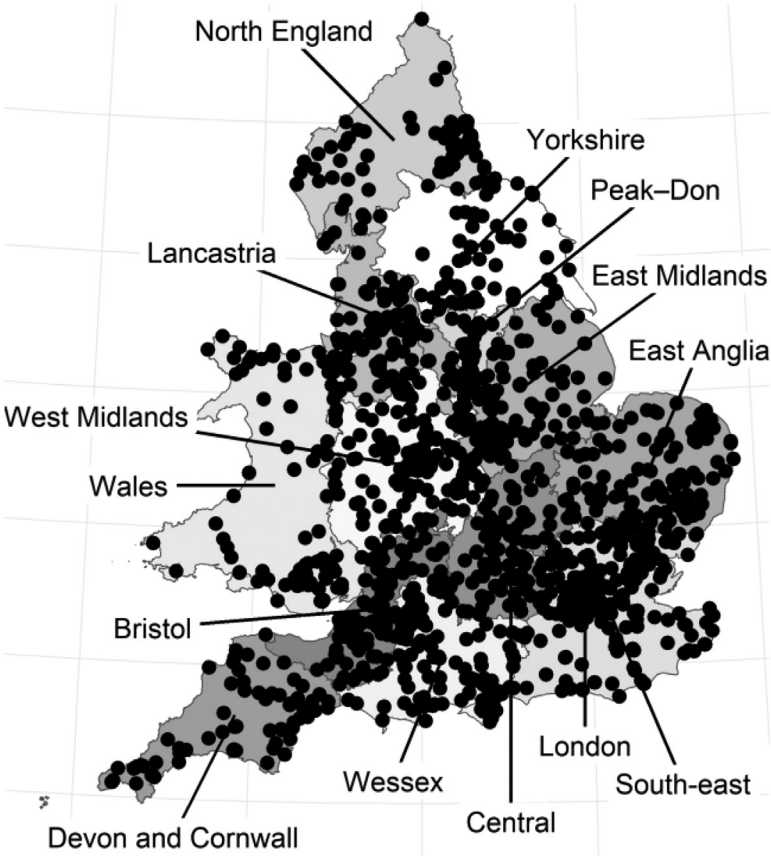

MAP 1
LOCATIONS OF ELECTION VIOLENCE, 1832–1910. THE BOUNDARY LINES DELINEATE THE REGIONS OF ENGLAND AS DEFINED IN HENRY PELLING, *SOCIAL GEOGRAPHY OF BRITISH ELECTIONS, 1885–1910* (LONDON, 1967).

era, incidents of violence were far less frequent than in the mid Victorian period. If we analyse violence by the proportion of constituencies experiencing at least one incident per general election rather than by raw count (Figure 2), we find this effect only marginally reduced. Indeed, across the period 1832–59, 24.9 per cent of constituency elections experienced election violence, rising to 45.6 per cent during the 1865–85 period, and falling to just 14.5 per cent during 1886–1910.

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Table 1 shows large regional differences in the proportion of elections affected by violence. For example, rates in East Anglia and the East Midlands are roughly double those in London and Wales. In part, these differences arise from strategic electoral considerations (which we examine in more detail below), although further regional interpretation requires considerable caution. For example, Wales shows lower levels of electoral violence partly as a result of lower levels of electoral contestation. This difference largely disappears when uncontested elections are excluded (see Table 1). Interpretative caution is required, however, because electoral violence over time is not stable. Even London (which saw, on average, the lowest rate) did not experience low levels consistently, as shown in Figure 3 for the periods outside 1885–1910. In this case, the cross-period average for London is pulled down by the low reading for 1885–1910 (where London also possessed many more consistencies following redistribution).

However, the crucial point is revealed by the triangular pattern shown in Figure 3, which is common across all thirteen English regions and Wales: namely, of (relatively) moderate violence in the 1832–65 period, followed by (relatively) high violence in the 1868–80 period, followed by (relatively) low violence in the 1885–1910 period. We should recall that the overall national pattern could have been constituted by radically different regional trends, but our analysis instead shows the pattern persisting even at each regional level, giving us considerably more confidence in its robustness.

The trendlines in Figures 1, 2 and 3, which are maintained even when the five robustness checks outlined in the Appendix are factored in, are highly contrarian. They are clearly incompatible with accounts of scholars of political development stressing gradualist peaceful democratic evolution after 1832. Likewise, they seem contrary to those of high political historians keen to emphasize the flowering of the age of equipoise, in which political battles were fought with words and coalitions in parliament rather than with fists and weapons on the streets. Finally, it is problematic for more recent historians of political culture. Old ritual culture, with its attendant violence and disorder, was, according to Vernon, O'Gorman and Baer, supposedly terminally on the wane by the 1860s (or earlier) as popular

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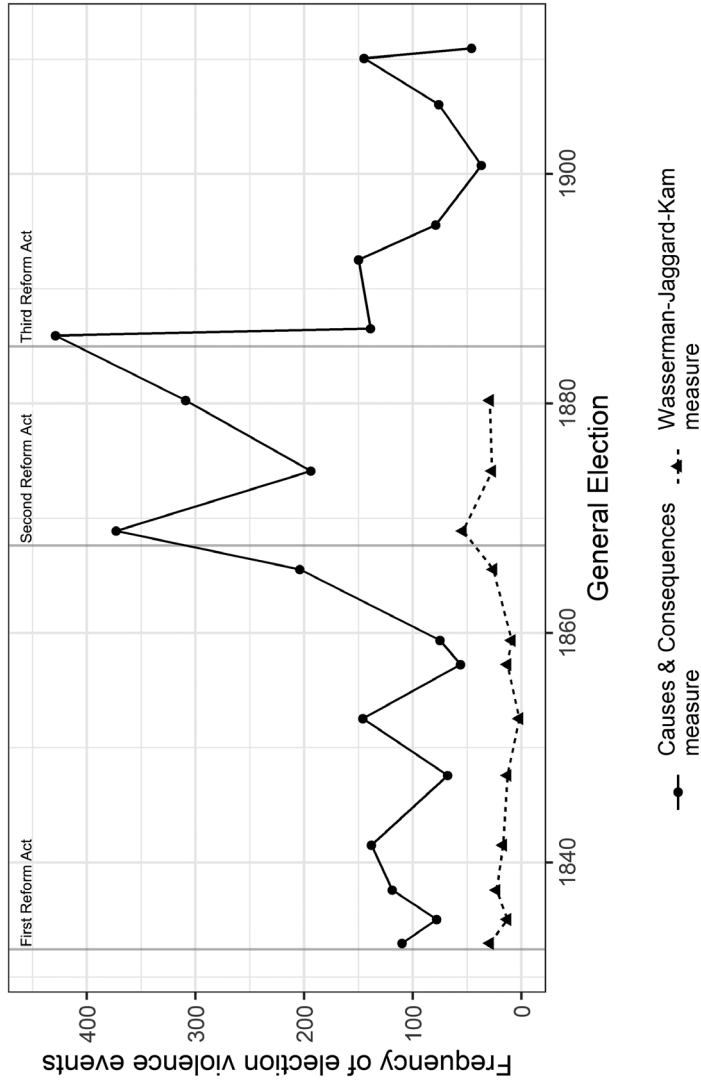
FIGURE 1

FREQUENCY OF ELECTION VIOLENCE, 1832–1910



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politics was tamed by the rise of party.[45] But Figure 2 also shows that electoral violence did not simply continue at a similar frequency until the First World War, as we might expect according to Lawrence's thesis, but declined markedly from 1886. Despite this seemingly stark challenge to historians past and present, it would be remiss to omit the caveat that previous scholars (with the partial exception of Wasserman and Jaggard and Kam) have never attempted to offer anything approaching specific election-by-election commentaries on national trends in electoral violence. Rather, we find a stark difference between what we might strongly expect to see given existing commentaries, and what we actually see having aggregated our data.

Having identified 1868–85 as the apogee of electoral violence, a more granular election-by-election analysis of this crucial period is revealing. Turning first to 1868, we find that an increased franchise cannot credibly explain the dramatic increase in violence compared to 1865. Serious episodes occurred across the country. For example, at the nomination for East Cumberland, in Wigton, a man's arrest triggered an incident in which an election crowd followed police to their station house, threw missiles, broke the windows and injured officers, the affair eventually descending into a reading of the Riot Act.[46] In Havant, southern Hampshire, roughs and 'lambs' ('lamb' being a specific euphemism for roughs in some locales) disturbed the peace, destroyed property and inflicted numerous injuries. Conservative voters were targeted, and had difficulty polling because of the attacks.[47] In East Kent, after the polling at Whitstable, a man was charged with encouraging a mob of about a hundred people to enter a pub with the purpose of assaulting a police sergeant.[48] To the west, a party supporter at Llanelli knocked down a member of the crowd with his horse, whereupon the crowd attacked the rider en masse.[49] The thirty-nine

[45] Vernon, *Politics and the People*; O'Gorman, 'Ritual Aspects of Popular Politics in England'; O'Gorman, 'Campaign Rituals and Ceremonies'; Baer, *Rise and Fall of Radical Westminster*.

[46] *Wigton Advertiser*, 28 Nov. 1868.

[47] *Portsmouth Times and Naval Gazette*, 28 Nov. 1868.

[48] *Whitstable Times and Herne Bay Herald*, 5 Dec. 1868.

[49] *Bristol Mercury*, 28 Nov. 1868.

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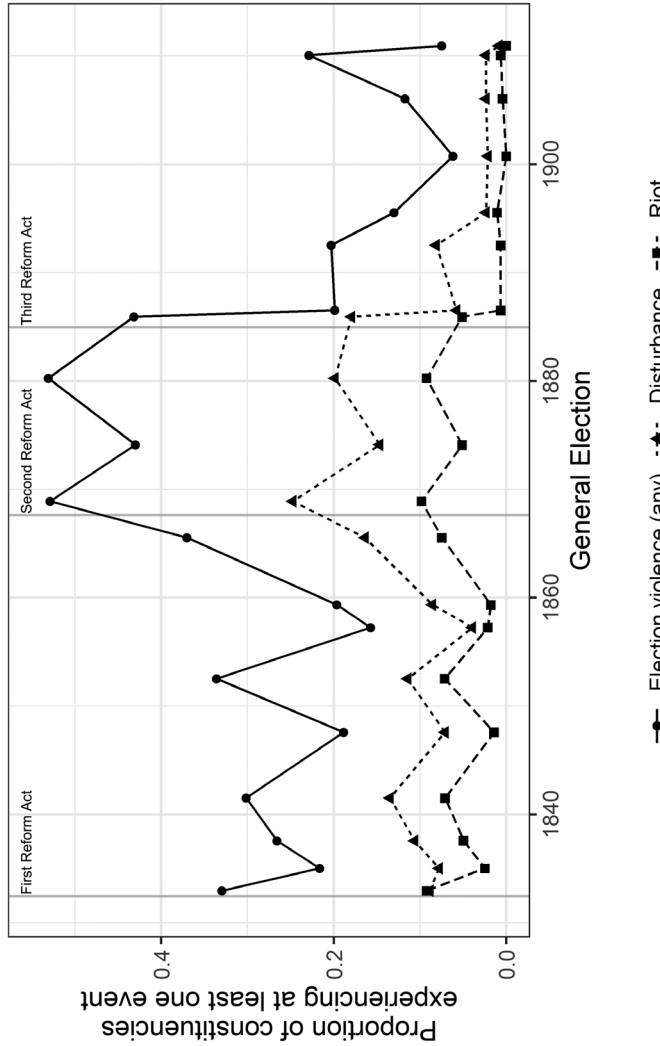
FIGURE 2

PROPORTION OF CONSTITUENCIES EXPERIENCING DIFFERENT TYPES OF ELECTION VIOLENCE AT EACH GENERAL ELECTION, 1832–1910



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geographically and demographically diverse riots of this election compare intriguingly to the twenty-six experienced in 1832, the previous election held in the wake of the passage of a Reform Act, as does its respective death tally of seventeen in 1832 compared to twenty in 1868. Though violent in comparison to later contests in that decade, the campaign of 1832 was remarkably sedate when compared to the two years of near-constant mass violence that had preceded it, which featured the burning of Nottingham Castle, extreme rioting in Derby, Worcester and Bath, and a likely 120–250 deaths in Bristol alone.[50] Thus, the violence in 1868 cannot be dismissed as the natural teething troubles of a mass enfranchisement and redistribution: the omens were far graver in 1832, but that election turned out to be unexpectedly peaceful.

The violence of 1868 showed little evidence of subsiding in the next general election, in 1874, despite the advent of secret voting two years previously. It was the third most violent in our period, a finding which presents a strong counter to Charles Seymour's view that the Ballot Act caused violence to 'almost entirely disappear . . . from electoral contests'.[51] It could also not be said that violence after 1872 simply represented the drawn-out death rattle of venality in the most historically 'rotten' constituencies. For example, according to our database records, East Retford, in Nottinghamshire, had no prior history of electoral violence (we record no incidents in 1832–74), but after one peaceful post-ballot contest, we record four incidents across the next seven general elections. In 1880 a group of Conservative roughs instigated a disturbance during the Liberal candidate's post-polling speech, leading to several injuries and police intervention. In 1885 the constituency (now renamed Bassetlaw, although featuring almost identical boundaries) saw considerable damage done to local property by roughs, including an indiscriminate assault on the populace involving the throwing of fish-heads, while a police officer was struck in the face with a stone.[52] In January 1910, a political meeting became rowdy,

[50] Mark Harrison, *Crowds and History: Mass Phenomena in English Towns, 1790–1835* (Cambridge, 1988), 299–300.

[51] Seymour, *Electoral Reform in England and Wales*, 432.

[52] *Sheffield Independent*, 2 Apr. 1880; *Yorkshire Post and Leeds Intelligencer*, 8 Dec. 1885.

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TABLE 1

REGIONAL VARIATION IN ELECTION VIOLENCE AND ELECTION RIOTS, 1832–1910

Region	Elections with violence (%)	Contests with violence (%)	Elections with riot (%)	Contests with riot (%)
East Anglia	35	45	15	18
East Midlands	35	42	16	20
Bristol	33	42	14	18
Central	33	43	13	17
Peak–Don	27	31	17	19
West Midlands	27	36	12	16
South-east	26	35	8	11
Wessex	25	35	10	15
Devon and Cornwall	24	33	9	13
North England	21	29	8	10
Lancastria	21	24	12	13
Yorkshire	20	23	10	11
Wales	18	30	8	14
London	16	17	5	5

leading to a forced eviction, and in a separate incident, roughs created a disturbance outside the 'dumping' shop'.[53] ('Dumping shops' were propagandistic displays employed by protectionist Unionists, showcasing foreign products 'dumped' onto the market by foreign competitors to British producers.) One threw a brick through a large window of the shop before the roughs were dispersed by the police. Even in the supposedly sanitized electoral world after the ballot, with its associated ban on the highly ritualized nomination day and the hustings, it was still possible for even a historically peaceable constituency to experience sudden repeated outbreaks of electoral violence.

The following election, in 1880, has often been seen as the first modern election owing to Gladstone's Midlothian campaign and the emergence of more sophisticated party organization, notably the National Liberal Federation, founded in 1877. The rise of disciplined party machines (featuring

[53] *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 13 and 25 Jan. 1910.

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organization and central leadership) has been identified by Vernon and O'Gorman as a key instigator of the decline of the old campaign rituals and their associated disorder. Despite this, Figure 2 again suggests a particularly violent election, with just over half of English and Welsh constituencies experiencing at least one episode. This contrasts with historians' assessments, which emphasize the persistence of bribery unconnected to violence.[54] Further light can be shed on the relationship between violence and party organization by focusing on Birmingham, the constituency boasting the country's most sophisticated party organization in the form of the Liberal caucus.[55] At Ladywood, roughs fraudulently represented themselves as special constables to prevent entry to polling stations; at St Paul's, fifty drunken Tory bullies threatened electors, requiring half a dozen police to be called in; at St Stephen's, roughs allegedly prevented Liberals from voting and demanded money before storming the committee rooms, requiring the intervention of a dozen constables.[56] Two elections prior to this, in 1868, even the caucus's sophisticated organization, which involved instructing Liberal electors on which two of their party's three candidates they should vote for to circumvent the 'minority clause', coexisted with a disturbance involving a crowd of sixty to seventy thousand, and disorder caused by clashing hired roughs from both sides.[57] In the aftermath of the Aston reform riots of 1884, Joseph Chamberlain and Randolph Churchill fiercely accused each other's party associations in Birmingham of hiring roughs and destroying the evidence.[58] Both men were accusing their opponent's local party organization not just of failing to quell violence, but of actually instigating it. The surprising conclusion appears to be that party organization and electoral violence might not simply coexist, but could actively feed each other.

Figure 2's reading for the election of 1885, held after the Corrupt and Illegal Practices Act became law, is also striking.

[54] See Rix, '"Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections"?', 68; Hanham, *Elections and Party Management*, 266–7.

[55] See Trygve R. Tholfsen, 'The Origins of the Birmingham Caucus', *Historical Journal*, ii, 2 (1959).

[56] *Birmingham Daily Post*, 1 Apr. 1880.

[57] *Birmingham Journal*, 2 Nov. 1868.

[58] Hansard, 3rd ser., ccxciii, cols. 543–92 (30 Oct. 1884).

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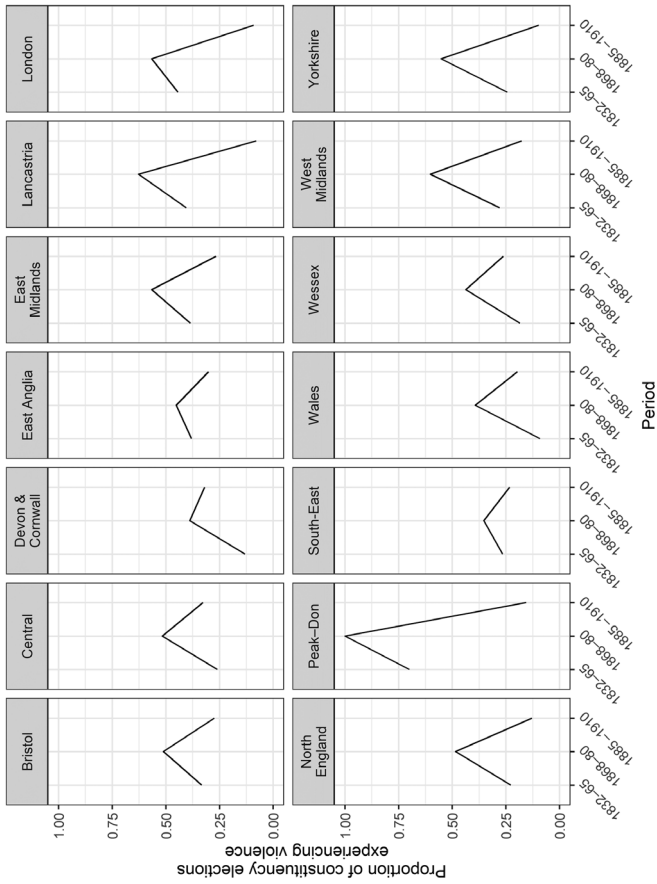
FIGURE 3

REGIONAL TRENDS IN ELECTION VIOLENCE, 1832–1910: PROPORTION OF CONSTITUENCY ELECTIONS EXPERIENCING ELECTION VIOLENCE IN EACH PELLING REGION (SEE MAP) ACROSS THREE PERIODS



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While (according to some measures) the campaign saw slightly less violence than occurred in 1880, it is clear that the Act did not enjoy immediate success in curbing disorder, despite its widely recognized impact in curtailing bribery. When it is also considered that party organization had made further strides since 1880 (symbolized by the founding of the Primrose League and the rapid expansion of Liberal associations affiliated to the National Liberal Federation), it seems, at least initially, that violence was not curbed either by legislative action from above or by organizational development from below.

A further important observation from the data for 1885 is that the extent of the bias towards violence in county constituencies was notably larger than in previous elections. Borough (broadly urban) and county (broadly rural) constituencies are the two main historic categories of constituency that have elected members of parliament to the House of Commons, and continue to exist today. Until 1884 they also elected members based on different franchise rules. In that year, the Third Reform Act extended household and lodger suffrage to all counties, when, since 1867, it had existed only for boroughs. It also substantially altered constituency boundaries and the distribution of seats.[59] These divisions had been transformed by redistribution and the enfranchisement of the agricultural labourer, and 55.3 per cent featured at least one violent incident compared to 28.8 per cent of boroughs. Indeed, by this same measure, counties were also more violent than boroughs in all seven subsequent elections before the First World War. The finding that an immediate consequence of the democratic upheaval of county politics ushered in after the Third Reform Act met with a bloody baptism in the countryside has gone virtually entirely unremarked in the historiography, which has tended to cast the outcome of the reforms of 1883–5 in extremely placid and utilitarian terms.[60]

[59] For a summary, see Angus Hawkins, *Victorian Political Culture: 'Habits of Heart and Mind'* (Oxford, 2015), 320–25.

[60] See, for example, Richard Shannon, *The Age of Salisbury, 1881–1902: Unionism and Empire* (London, 1996), 76.

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IV

EXPLAINING ELECTORAL VIOLENCE STRATEGICALLY

The levels and trends uncovered above appear to challenge the two dominant historiographical explanations of electoral violence: the high politics school, who neglect election violence, and both opposing 'cultural' views of ritualized violence as something that either declined by the 1860s (O'Gorman, Vernon and others) or persisted into and beyond the 1890s (Lawrence). The natural next question is how and how far a political explanation for electoral violence, that it was used strategically by party elites and their agents, fits the evidence. Unsurprisingly, despite the ubiquitous evidence of its occurrence, admissions of political elites organizing electoral violence are largely absent from the usual sources that might reveal motivation for culpability such as personal archives, diaries and autobiographies. For instance, archival research focused on electoral violence in Lancashire constituencies revealed no unequivocal evidence, despite examination of papers in various repositories including the Lancashire Archives in Preston, Blackburn with Darwen Central Library, and the National Archives, Kew. An illustrative case of fairly clear-cut elite collusion in political violence can be observed in the Scottish constituency of Roxburghshire during the immediate post-Reform period. Even then, despite the survival of extensive personal political correspondence from relevant elites, no 'smoking gun' connecting them to its orchestration survives.[61] These sources do contain many accounts of election violence, including accusations of strategic targeting, but almost exclusively from the targets rather than the perpetrators.[62] It is, however, hardly surprising that politicians would seek to downplay their own misconduct, especially when we consider that the damages caused by violence (property destruction, injuries and death) were often more serious than other technically illegal yet tolerated electoral corruption such as bribery and treating. This

[61] See Gary D. Hutchison, '"Party Principles" in Scottish Political Culture: Roxburghshire, 1832–1847', *Scottish Historical Review*, xcviii, suppl., 248 (2019).

[62] See, for example, the accounts of George Lansbury, Thomas Wright and Joseph Howe, cited in Lawrence, *Speaking for the People*, 181–8. However, as Lawrence notes, Will Thorne, *My Life's Battles* (London, 1925), provides a rare exception when he recalls violence from the perpetrator's perspective.

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incentivized politicians to be gung-ho about accusing opponents of instigating disruption but reluctant to admit organizing it themselves. A similar tendency applies to the archival collections of the personal papers of elites or their agents, exacerbated by later processes of editing, and in extreme cases the wholesale burning of documents on death.[63] A good example is the trial concerning the Aston reform riots of 1884, in which hired roughs were alleged to be involved. Supposedly incriminating papers concerning their hiring were destroyed, and much of the evidence was reduced to allegations of untraceable and unprovable verbal communication between agents and roughs.[64] The relative dearth of evidence in the usual sources is thus unsurprising, and raises an important historiographical point about how far we can trust carefully curated private sources to give a complete, or even partial, picture of illicit activity such as election violence.

Given those problems, this section argues for the importance of strategic motivations in two ways. First, it provides an examination of the role of hired roughs in elections, making the argument that they were an extremely frequent cause of violence in the period 1832–85, and local parties often saw them as an indispensable electioneering resource. Second, it examines three further statistical relationships that strengthen the hypothesis that roughs were used not only by local political elites and their agents but also in strategically optimal or explicable electoral contexts: namely, when elections were contested, when races were tight, and where party coherency and organization was strongest. Throughout this section, we restrict our analysis to electoral violence occurring before or during polling (hereafter labelled 'pre-election violence'), because violence after polling is of much less direct strategic value to candidates seeking to affect electoral outcomes.

We focus primarily on hired roughs to make the argument that violence was frequently organized by candidate campaigns. We do not claim that all electoral violence was organized, that elites

[63] See, for example, Alistair Lexden, 'A Tragic Tory Leader and his Diaries', *Parliamentary History*, xxxvii, 3 (2018), 437–8, on the fate of the papers of Sir Stafford Northcote.

[64] See *Dundee Courier*, 28 Nov. 1884; Hansard, 3rd ser., ccxciii, cols. 543–647 (30 Oct. 1884).

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were its sole orchestrators, or that hired roughs were exclusively incentivized by money. Hired roughs may also have had multiple motivations for involvement and have been prepared to lend their muscle more willingly and more cheaply to their preferred candidate. However, hired roughs are nonetheless close to a *sui generis* embodiment of strategic election violence because they were so clearly organized, planned and financed, and can sometimes be directly tied to candidates and particularly to their agents.

Despite his obvious importance, the hired rough remains a mysterious and shadowy character in the dramatis personae of Victorian elections, and while numerous works have explored the roles of candidates, agents, party workers, volunteers, pressure group activists, newspaper editors and non-electors, nothing dedicated has been written about him. Hired roughs had two main strategic functions: to use physical force (or the threat of it) against opponents, and to guard against opposition roughs attempting to do the same. The widespread involvement of hired roughs can be demonstrated by pointing to Figure 4, which shows that a substantial proportion of all pre-election violence involved hired roughs, at least until 1885. In nine of those twelve elections more than 5 per cent of constituencies experienced pre-election violence with hired roughs, and in six at least 10 per cent of constituencies did so. The role of hired roughs is further demonstrated by the fact that 25.7 per cent of pre-election violence events involve hired roughs, which rises to 40.1 per cent if we focus only on more severe election violence events (riots and disturbances).

To investigate the role of hired roughs, events were coded as 'hired roughs involved' if roughs (assisted by a taxonomy of their many monikers) were recorded either as the direct cause, or as an indirect feature, of electoral violence, in one or more newspaper reports. Coders were trained to pay specific attention to the broader context of newspaper reports to determine whether the roughs were hired (or allegedly hired) rather than just being pejoratively described as 'rough' characters or similar. Naturally, newspapers' ascriptions of hired roughs being involved are subject to potential bias: see the Appendix for details on how we accounted for this. We thus do not contend that other causes of electoral violence did not continue to be important, for example ritualistic cultural causes or partisanship, but that when electoral

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violence was most severe (and likely politically salient), hired roughs, and the strategic election violence they represented, were likeliest to be involved.

Hired roughs went by many names. Generic monikers included 'bullies', 'bludgeon-men', 'toughs' and 'thugs'. More nebulous 'defensive' labels were 'watchers', 'special watchers', 'night watchers', 'protection men', and 'procession men' and 'doorkeepers'.[65] Overwhelmingly male and working-class, they were drawn from various localities, groups and occupations. They were unlikely to be electors. Many were notoriously indiscriminate about whom they worked for, although we cannot assume an absence of political preference, for they might, in some instances, work for one side exclusively, for a discounted fee, or refuse employment from a particularly disliked candidate or agent. While concrete examples of hired roughs expressing political preferences are rare (in large part because of the inherent difficulty in ascertaining the motivations of such individuals, who were unlikely to leave diaries and memoirs), our database suggests that some may have had political preferences. For example, Irish roughs were likelier to work for Liberal candidates, and sometimes candidates who were unpopular locally were likelier to bring in roughs from outside rather than engage the 'local element'. In 1832, for instance, the group of roughs hired to terrorize Liberal inhabitants of Hertford were 'gypsies', or travellers, who had not previously resided in the area, camping in a field owned by the Conservative mayor.[66] More generally, roughs were outsiders otherwise engaged in peripatetic occupations outwith election time, and were brought to constituencies specifically for electioneering purposes.[67] An example of this is the East Suffolk election of 1859, when the Conservatives placed a gang of prize fighters at the entrance to a polling place in Ipswich, headed by Ben Caunt, a bare-knuckle prize fighter who had been English heavyweight champion for almost all

[65] *Report of the Royal Commission Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Parliamentary Election for the City of Norwich*, Parliamentary Papers, 1876 (C. 1442), xxvii, 7.

[66] *Report from the Select Committee on the Hertford Election Petition: With the Minutes of Proceedings and the Evidence Taken Before Them*, HC 1833 (152), ix, 56.

[67] *Norfolk News*, 14 May 1859.

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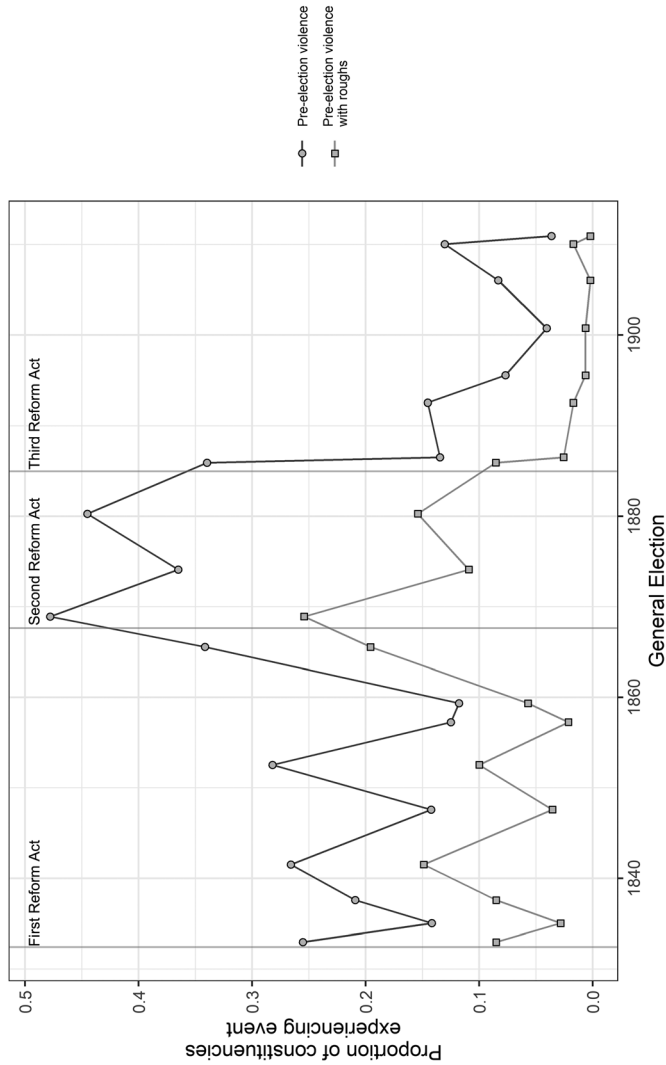
FIGURE 4

PROPORTION OF CONSTITUENCIES EXPERIENCING ANY TYPE OF PRE-ELECTION VIOLENCE AND PRE-ELECTION VIOLENCE INVOLVING ALL FORMS OF HIRED ROUGHS, 1832–1910



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of the period 1838–45.[68] In other cases, roughs might already be working in the area; for example, in the 1892 election the local 'Gladstonite' prize fighter of Tipton, Staffordshire, William Regan, was fined for assault, having allegedly been given a 'roving commission to bully and assault people'.[69] Earlier in the century, it was common for roughs to be hired from the ranks of navvies engaged in local or distant infrastructure projects. In 1832, for instance, Coventry Conservatives hired navvies on 10 December (henceforth dubbed 'the bloody Tenth'). They were arranged in rows to prevent Reform electors from casting their votes, although, as it transpired, they were overwhelmed, beaten and driven out of the city.[70] Insider-type roughs who resided permanently within or near the locality were usually drawn from the 'local element': groups of unemployed or underemployed young men. Such groups might already be organized in gangs for hire. In Birmingham in the 1880s, for instance, political roughs were drawn from the city's Cecil Street gang, Harding Street gang, Lench Street gang and Great Bar Street gang, 'under the Brothers Reed, two notorious pugilists'.[71] In some cases, particular local industries might provide the required muscle, such as colliers or millworkers.

Hired roughs were usually most active on polling day itself. In the earlier nineteenth century, small electorates and public ballots made it feasible to target electors individually, as occurred at Hertford in 1832, where roughs named 'Beef Steak Sam', 'Centre Bit Jack' and 'Dicky Nipper' stood accused of assaulting targeted local inhabitants to discourage them from voting.[72] A more elaborate variation of this was the practice of 'cooping' (that is, kidnapping electors), which occurred at Macclesfield in 1865, where roughs seized several voters, drugged them, and transported them out of the constituency.[73] Roughs could be employed simply to loiter conspicuously outside polling booths to create an atmosphere of intimidation to suppress opposition

[68] 'Benjamin Caunt', *Encyclopedia Britannica*, <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Benjamin-Caunt> (accessed 11 Mar. 2024).

[69] *Gloucestershire Echo*, 21 July 1892.

[70] *Coventry Herald*, 23 July 1852.

[71] Hansard, 3rd ser., ccxciii, col. 562 (30 Oct. 1884).

[72] *Report from the Select Committee on the Hertford Election Petition*, evidence line c.11559.

[73] *Durham County Advertiser*, 28 July 1865.

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turnout. This occurred at Bristol in 1837, where Conservatives hired roughs armed with bludgeons to deter Liberal electors from approaching the polling place.[74] These sorts of tactics, in which roughs targeted certain vote-casters and protected others, were more effective prior to the secret ballot, but even after 1872 roughs could still be fruitfully (albeit less precisely) employed to suppress turnout at stations or districts where opposition parties were known to be strong, or to attack prominent partisan figures. During the polling in Wareham, Dorset, in 1880, for instance, Liberals allegedly hired a large body of drunken roughs for the general purpose of 'interfering with freedom of election', but they also directly assaulted colour-wearing supporters of the Conservative candidate, John Erle-Drax, and eventually Drax himself.[75] Similarly, in Birmingham in the same election, roughs calling themselves 'special constables' blocked access to polling booths.[76]

Outside of violence on polling day itself, roughs could disrupt opposition campaigns. An obvious role was to tear down posters and party colours to weaken an opposing campaign's visual vitality and momentum.[77] Examples included Aston Manor, Warwickshire, in 1886, where two bill-posters working for the Liberal candidate, Hugh Reid, were knocked down (and one hospitalized), and Ilford, Essex, in 1885, where gangs of roughs patrolled the streets with cans of 'blue wash' to deface Liberal posters, before eventually forcing access to the Liberal committee rooms and emptying the wash over its occupants.[78] Events drawing crowds were also ripe targets, especially nominations, the hustings and (especially from the 1870s) political meetings. Roughs could be employed to heckle opposition speakers to deny them hearings, ask awkward or impertinent questions, throw missiles at the platform (including mud, rotten eggs, herrings, turnips, rocks and bricks), or start crowd fights. During the Bristol election in 1859, for instance, a

[74] *Western Daily Press*, 26 Nov. 1868.

[75] *Dorset County Chronicle*, 8 Apr. 1880.

[76] *Birmingham Daily Post*, 1 Apr. 1880.

[77] James Thompson, '"Pictorial Lies"? Posters and Politics in Britain, *c.*1880–1914', *Past and Present*, no. 197 (Nov. 2007), 210.

[78] *Essex Herald*, 5 Dec. 1885; *Birmingham Daily Post*, 5 July 1886.

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'hireling mob' of colliers, hauliers, lumpers and alleged criminals, wearing party-colour cards in their caps, amassed at the nomination, starting fights in the crowd and drowning out the Conservative candidate, Frederick Slade's, speech.[79] Roughs engaged in 'crowd work' could, however, find themselves the targets of counter-violence as supporters of the opposing candidate fought back (sometimes with their own hired roughs). This occurred at the hustings in Wakefield in 1868, where the predominantly Liberal crowd refused to hear the local Conservative Alderman Shaw, on whose behalf hired roughs responded by pelting the Liberal side of the hustings with stones, who in turn fought back, causing the event to descend into a serious riot.[80]

Like bribery, it appears that hired roughs were not only tolerated, but seen as semi-legitimate features of electioneering until at least the 1880s. In part this was because the ritual culture of elections, with free-flowing alcohol, marching bands, banner-led processions and other entertainments, created legal cover to employ men as colour-carriers and the like.[81] This was taken to extremes in Carlisle in 1852, when 495 'bludgeon-men', whose candidate, William Hodgson, had lost, accosted and besieged local Conservatives to demand payment for their employment as 'colour-carriers'. Indeed, the bludgeon-men unsuccessfully pursued a case of non-payment with the local magistrate before reaching an out-of-court settlement with Hodgson.[82] In Sheffield in 1865, a similar instance of roughs, who had been 'raiding about the town' during the day and had smashed windows in the evening, self-identified as legitimate election workers, presenting themselves at the Liberal committee rooms because the party had offered to distribute payment to 'the check-clerk, canvassers, writers, and others'.[83] At Walsall in 1874, a newspaper editor complained of the ease with which 'Roughs' were employed 'under the pretence of their being either messengers

[79] *Western Daily Press*, 29 Apr. 1859. Lumpers were men employed to unload freight.

[80] *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 21 Nov. 1868.

[81] Christopher Kam, 'The Secret Ballot and the Market for Votes at Nineteenth-Century British Elections', *Comparative Political Studies*, l, 5 (2017), 598.

[82] *Carlisle Journal*, 16 July 1852.

[83] *Morning Advertiser*, 17 July 1865.

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or protectors of voters and preservers of the peace'.[84] As well as their legal employability as colour-carriers, election ritual could also give legal cover to engage roughs as entertainment, for example as pugilists. In 1837 at Lincoln, 'the pugilistic champion of the Reform crowd . . . was borne about the city with lighted torches in the evening by way of crowing over the conquered foe'.[85]

A second reason why hiring roughs did not always raise eyebrows was their defensive utility as 'peacekeepers' or 'bodyguards' for candidates or electors. During the canvass for Norwich in 1868, for instance, Liberals hired bodyguards after their meeting at the Lamb pub was disrupted by Conservative roughs, resulting in injuries and broken windows.[86] In 1868 the Conservative candidate complained of a 'reign of terror' against his party in Spittal and Tweedmouth, Northumberland, claiming that 'the Conservatives would not provoke a breach of the peace; but would defend themselves, and take means to defend those in whom they are interested from damage either to their persons or property'.[87] Indeed, the royal commission investigating Norwich elections in 1876 concluded that such an attitude was widespread, discovering that an individual elector had hired a personal bodyguard because he had been assaulted at a previous election. The leader of the Norwich Conservative Party directly testified to having employed defensive roughs en masse: 'I would protect defensively, not offensively, all meetings of the party in future; and I did . . . although I do not defend the practice on the ground of propriety, I must say I do on the ground of prudence'.[88]

The third and final reason why roughs were widely tolerated was because the police failed to subdue them.[89] Our data clearly demonstrates that the new arrangements following the County

[84] *Walsall Free Press*, 14 Feb. 1874.

[85] *Stamford Mercury*, 28 July 1837.

[86] *Report of the Commissioners Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Election for Members to Serve in Parliament for the City of Norwich*, Parliamentary Papers, 1870 (C. 13–14), xxxi, 21.

[87] *Newcastle Daily Journal*, 11 Nov. 1868.

[88] *Report of the Royal Commission Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Parliamentary Election for the City of Norwich* (1876), 1083, 14.

[89] For a more detailed examination of the relationship between police reform and election violence in this period, see G. Cohen, G. Hutchison and P. M. Kuhn, 'Policing and Election Violence: Evidence from England and Wales, 1832–1914', unpubd working paper (2022).

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and Borough Police Act of 1856 (and the associated increase in police numbers in subsequent decades) failed to resolve the problem of electoral violence, which rose to its highest level in the period before it receded from the mid 1880s. This was mainly because, despite the aim to establish substantial, regulated, trained, disciplined and professional forces (partly on account of a growing fear of widespread disorder), electoral policing often continued to rely on untrained and hastily recruited special constables through to the later part of the century.[90] The number of regular police in most areas remained very small, and infrequent special events such as elections required the drafting-in of additional constables.[91] The use of such special police for elections had increased following the Special Constables Act of 1820, which made it easier to appoint specials temporarily with extensive legal powers who were paid an hourly wage for their services.[92] Special constables were recommended by the Home Office as a cost-efficient cure for a wide range of policing issues, and authorities were advised to recruit in large numbers in advance of, or in response to, unrest, including that associated with elections.

However, there were persistent general concerns about the poor calibre of special police and their lack of training and discipline.[93] Indeed, special constables were often drawn from the 'local element', tasked with no official duties (effectively

[90] Martin Stallion and David S. Wall, *The British Police: Forces and Chief Officers, 1829–2012*, 2nd edn (Hook, 2011); Robert D. Storch, 'The Plague of the Blue Locusts: Police Reform and Popular Resistance in Northern England, 1840–57', *International Review of Social History*, l, 1 (1975); Jenifer Hart, 'Reform of the Borough Police, 1835–1856', *English Historical Review*, lxx (1955); Henry Parris, 'The Home Office and the Provincial Police in England and Wales, 1856–1970', in Paul Lawrence (ed.), *The New Police in the Nineteenth Century* (Farnham, 2011).

[91] In addition to the size of the new police, there was considerable hostility to them: see Navickas, *Protest and the Politics of Space and Place*, 141–5. It is also important to bear in mind that the new police were not uniformly well characterized as a professional police force motivated to maintain public order, and that policing elections is anyway challenging: David Churchill, 'Local Initiative, Central Oversight, Provincial Perspective: Governing Police Forces in Nineteenth-Century Leeds', *Historical Research*, lxxxviii, 241 (2015); Roger Swift, 'Urban Policing in Early Victorian England, 1835–86: A Reappraisal', *History*, lxxiii, 238 (1988).

[92] Clare Leon, 'Special Constables and the Birth of "Regular" Policing', in Karen Bullock and Andrew Millie (eds.), *The Special Constabulary: Historical Context, International Comparisons and Contemporary Themes* (London, 2018), 35.

[93] Clare Leon, 'Special Constables: An Historical and Contemporary Survey' (University of Bath Ph.D. thesis, 1991), 224.

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an official bribe) to prevent local parties from hiring them as roughs.[94] In 1868 in Salisbury, for instance, the authorities ensured the peace by swearing in 'all the roughs of the town' as 'Special Constables' and keeping them 'in reserve' at the Market House for the duration of the election.[95] Similarly, at the North Wiltshire nomination in 1865, roughs were paid 5s. each to sit on their hands as 'specials'.[96] As late as 1895 in Biggleswade, Bedfordshire, authorities attempted to subdue a riot by promoting some of the most visibly desperate rioters to special constables, aiming to induce or frighten them into dispersing the rest of the crowd.[97] In practice many of the special constables engaged specifically for elections were clearly partisan and acted as roughs in uniform, which meant that the distinction between official unbiased peacekeeping force and unofficial partisan protection was murky at best. In 1853 the mayor of Blackburn's concern at potentially swearing in party men was allayed by the Home Office, which advised there was no bar on using partisans with a direct interest in the election as special police.[98] Such partisan tendencies were further exacerbated by the fact that special police were frequently paid by candidates, using the excuse that they were reducing the burden on ratepayers. Indeed, in 1852 the constituency of Ross, Herefordshire, witnessed a pitched battle between special constables associated with the different candidates.[99] It is no coincidence that in many elections, such as Ventnor in 1857 and Harwich in 1865, groups of roughs simply acquired the nickname 'specials' despite not having been officially sworn in.[100]

While the circumstantial evidence for roughs hired by political elites or their agents to influence elections is considerable, direct evidence of culpability is patchier. One example is during the

[94] This tactic was also used in the Swing riots and in Chartist disturbances: see Leon, 'Special Constables and the Birth of "Regular" Policing', 43.

[95] *Swindon Advertiser*, 26 Nov. 1868.

[96] *Manchester Courier*, 26 July 1865.

[97] *Bedfordshire Times and Independent*, 27 July 1895.

[98] Leon, 'Special Constables: An Historical and Contemporary Survey', 35.

[99] *Leicester Journal*, 23 July 1852.

[100] *Hampshire Advertiser*, 18 Apr. 1857; *Suffolk Chronicle*, 15 July 1865.

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1874 election in Shaftesbury, a town with an unusually competent and professional local police force which was not so reliant on special constables. A group of hired roughs arrived from London by train but were spotted en route and the local police superintendent forewarned of their arrival by telegraph. He arranged for constables to meet the roughs on arrival, and they were detained at the railway station, where they testified that they had had their rail fare paid and a sovereign placed in their hands with instructions to meet 'a certain Mr Price' at the Abbey Arms. 'Mr Price' turned out to be the chief agent of the Liberal candidate, Henry Danby Seymour.[101] As in this instance, plans usually had to go awry to implicate the candidate or his chief agent, as was the case with the Carlisle bludgeon-men of 1852, who were not paid and thus presented themselves to a magistrate.[102] Generally, though, roughs were hired by sub-agents, committee members or general prominent party supporters, thus providing a firebreak to the chief agent or candidate if the roughs themselves talked, freely or under detention. The aforementioned Macclesfield roughs who had kidnapped and drugged voters in 1865 claimed, after being caught, that they had been engaged by the Liberal candidate David Chadwick's campaign and 'were waiting instructions from Mr. ——, an active member of that gentleman's committee, as to how much further and where they should transport their prisoners'.[103] While networks of sub-agents could help to put distance between elites and hired muscle, the tendency of roughs to be organized into gangs or other groups meant that party figures only need deal with select gangmasters, who could act as effective subcontractors. In Norwich, mainly cattle-drover roughs were 'engaged by certain publicans who were well-known for their experience in this kind of business, and who were able to send from 25 to 50 men to any part of the city at the shortest notice'.[104] After violence in Sheffield in 1880, the murkiness of arrangements was sufficient to shield party elites from direct blame after an anonymous letter to the *Sheffield Independent* claimed that

[101] *Edinburgh Evening News*, 14 Feb. 1874; *Western Gazette*, 20 Feb. 1874.

[102] *Carlisle Journal*, 16 July 1852.

[103] *Durham County Advertiser*, 28 July 1865.

[104] *Report of the Royal Commission Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Parliamentary Election for the City of Norwich* (1876), 13.

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> The working men of Sheffield are not to blame for this, but the blame lies on some in higher places, who pay a lot of the lowest scoundrels they can find to attend meetings to create disturbances and knock men down . . . A short time ago I was told of one of these roughs presenting his bill of 30s. to an electioneering committee, and an honest working man, who happened to be a member of that committee, objected to the payment of it. Upon this another member of the committee, and a member of the Town Council, too, said it must be paid, or his honour was at stake, for he had engaged him.[105]

Given all the above, it seems highly probable that 'gentlemanly' candidates or their chief agents frequently directly ordered, or at least turned blind eyes to, the hiring of roughs to perpetrate violence or defend against opposition violence (which usually amounted to much the same). Members of parliament, no doubt fearing libel, could only accuse each other obliquely by pointing fingers at the organizational probity of opposing local parties *à la* Churchill and Chamberlain following the Aston reform riots. This was also true of ministers: in 1877 the home secretary, discussing election rioting at Great Grimsby, after convoluted references to the influence of 'foreign agents' and the 'lamb family of Nottingham', explicitly stated that he knew 'nothing, and [did] not wish to know anything, about the Great Grimsby election'.[106] Politicians and chief agents were more willing to discuss such matters before royal commissions, although hiring roughs was invariably primarily admitted to in the context of protecting against other roughs. One witness to the Norwich royal commission of 1876, however, was asked if he thought such defensive roughs actually helped to maintain the peace; he answered, 'No, I think rather the other way, to excite a quarrel wherever they go; I have every reason to believe it, they go with sticks and blue and white favours on, &c.'.[107] Also, while many expressed a strong belief that 'protectors' were necessary, excessive numbers of them seemed to be being hired, and one witness remarked that he thought that they 'unquestionably

[105] *Sheffield Independent*, 17 Apr. 1880.

[106] Hansard, 3rd ser., ccxxxvi, cols. 467–8 (6 Aug. 1877).

[107] *Report of the Royal Commission Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Parliamentary Election for the City of Norwich* (1876), 960; G. Cohen, G. Hutchison, P. M. Kuhn and N. Vivyan, 'Party Development and Election Violence: Evidence from Nineteenth Century England and Wales', unpubd working paper (2022).

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created a considerable disturbance and even obstruction of the poll'.[108] This reflected the obvious paradox that once one side had roughs (for whatever reason), the other felt obliged to follow suit, ensuring an arms race in which peace was the inevitable loser. Despite the somewhat embarrassed excuses made by their apologists, roughs were clearly hired for strategic purposes, and served, even in nebulous 'defensive capacities', to increase greatly the volume and severity of electoral violence.

The practice of hiring roughs long pre-dated 1832, and there are numerous examples of them featuring in eighteenth-century elections.[109] However, Figure 4 suggests that the apogee of the hired rough in Victorian electoral politics directly coincided with the apogee of pre-electoral violence in general. Evidently, the Second Reform Act and the Ballot Act did not serve to curtail the role of hired roughs any more than they served to curtail electoral violence generally. This is not hard to understand because the post-reform world inadvertently created circumstances that increased the comparative utility of using 'dirty money' to hire roughs rather than bribe electors. Roughs could attack mass political meetings and create generalized disruption on polling day for the same price as before, whereas bribery became extortionately expensive and unreliable in an age of large electorates and secret voting.[110] The apogee of the hired rough was a brief one, however, and from 1886, even given the context of a sharp decline in electoral violence overall, their involvement collapsed. Their decline in part went hand-in-hand with the decline in the legitimizing factors that sustained them. As the century progressed, violence became an increasingly unacceptable facet of everyday life, and as the entertainment and spectacle of elections declined, hiring pugilists was both less socially desirable and less practically justifiable. However, the

[108] *Report of the Royal Commission Appointed to Inquire into the Existence of Corrupt Practices at the Last Parliamentary Election for the City of Norwich* (1876), 13–14.

[109] See, for example, Baer, *Rise and Fall of Radical Westminster*, 112–116. A highly publicized example of extensive hired violence (including a subsequent murder trial) was the Middlesex election of 1768, which involved John Wilkes: see Joseph Grego, *A History of Parliamentary Elections and Electioneering in the Old Days: Showing the State of Political Parties and Party Warfare at the Hustings and in the House of Commons from the Stuarts to Queen Victoria. Illustrated from the Original Political Squibs, Lampoons, Pictorial Satires, and Popular Caricatures of the Time* (London, 1886), 179–89.

[110] Cohen *et al.*, 'Party Development and Election Violence'.

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more important factor was the strict limit on election spending and illegal payment brought in by the Corrupt Practices Act of 1883, which meant that hiring large groups of election workers or colour-carriers as organizational cover for roughs was rendered exceptionally risky, especially in view of the Act's vicarious clause that newly elected members of parliament could be unseated by the wrongdoing of even a low-paid sub-agent. We discuss the tentative reasons for the passage and the importance of this Act in section V.

While developments in policing were extremely patchy throughout the middle of the century, localities with more professional and numerous police forces could sometimes remove the need (and the excuse) to hire 'defensive roughs'. The apprehending of the gang at Shaftesbury railway station in 1874 was made possible only by the number of available policeman, a professional and impartial superintendent and mayor, and their ability both to receive and to act on a chance advance warning provided by modern telegraphic communication.[111] This enabled not only the roughs to be caught before they struck, but culpability to be traced back to the Liberal chief agent who had employed them. Towards the end of the century, policing began to improve, and more forces became like Shaftesbury's, and fewer like that of Newport (Isle of Wight), which, in the same decade, had found their tiny constabulary of five policemen overwhelmed by electoral violence they would otherwise have probably been able to prevent.

While our analysis of hired roughs supports their significance and link with political elites and their agents, the broader argument that electoral violence was often strategic can also be supported by examining its relationship with constituency competitiveness: to test the hypothesis that violence was likelier to be used where the race between opposing candidates was tighter. While Victorian parties lacked modern psephological intelligence on seat marginality, they usually had a good idea, whether from past elections, the canvass or the annual voter registrations established in 1832, whether a constituency election would be competitive or not, and would sometimes withdraw candidates

[111] Hansard, 3rd ser., ccii, cols. 1354–6 (4 July 1870); *Edinburgh Evening News*, 14 Feb. 1874; *Western Gazette*, 20 Feb. 1874.

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if they thought they would lose. If electoral violence was purely cultural and unconnected to political strategy, we might expect there to be no statistical relationship between instances of violence and seat competitiveness. Indeed, we might also expect to see only a limited relationship between violence and whether a seat was even contested, because, as several historians argue, even uncontested elections could feature rituals involving large crowds and sometimes nominations, hustings, processions, lively debate and speeches, especially in instances where a campaign began normally before a candidate withdrew.[112]

Drawing upon recent political-science approaches, and adapting these to account for multi-member constituencies and the ambiguity of party labels for most of our period, we measure competitiveness in a constituency election by taking the minimum change in vote share that would secure a seat for a losing candidate (in double-member constituencies this is the vote share of the candidate who finished second minus that of the one who finished third, regardless of the party affiliation of those two candidates).[113] We define a 'marginal' constituency as one where a poll occurred and this gap was no more than ten percentage points, and a 'contested' constituency as one where a poll occurred and the gap was any size. Figure 5 shows trends in the proportion of constituency elections that were marginal, the proportion that were competitive, and the proportion experiencing election violence.

The period 1832–85 saw a general substantial rise in both the proportion of contested constituencies, and those which saw close results. (Recent work has suggested that the rise in contestation was due to changing socio-economic structures and the spread of literacy and newspapers.[114]) Perhaps intuitively, the proportion of constituencies experiencing election

[112] See Frank O'Gorman, *Voters, Patrons, and Parties: The Unreformed Electorate of Hanoverian England, 1734–1832* (Oxford, 1989), 150–54; D. Foster, 'The Politics of Uncontested Elections: North Lancashire, 1832–65', *Northern History*, xiii, 1 (1977); David Eastwood, 'Toryism, Reform, and Political Culture in Oxfordshire, 1826–1837', *Parliamentary History*, vii, 1 (1988).

[113] Gary W. Cox, Jon H. Fiva and Daniel M. Smith, 'Measuring the Competitiveness of Elections', *Political Analysis*, xxviii, 2 (2020).

[114] Christopher Kam and Adlai Newson, *The Economic Origins of Political Parties* (Cambridge, 2021).

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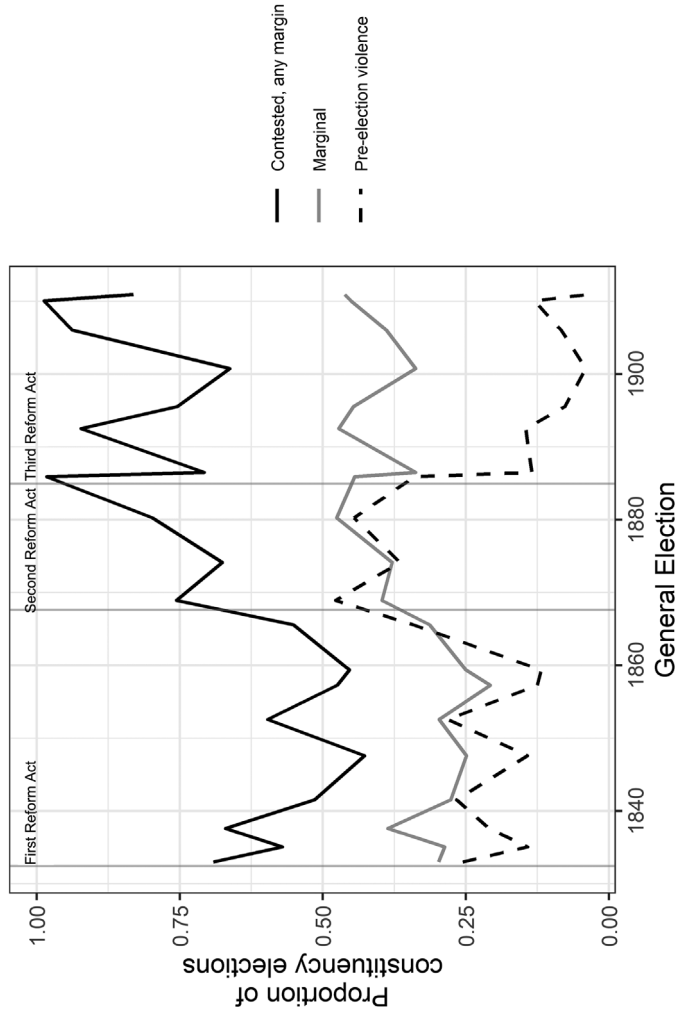
FIGURE 5

TEMPORAL RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN ELECTORAL VIOLENCE, CONTESTATION AND SEAT MARGINALITY, 1832–1910



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violence in this period trends with both the proportion of those contested (Pearson's correlation 0.7) and those classed as marginal (0.79). Furthermore, these associations generally hold when one compares across constituencies in each given general election, and when one focuses specifically on violence involving hired roughs. In each of the eleven general elections held during 1832–85, the percentage of marginal constituencies that experienced violence was greater (by an average of six percentage points) than the percentage of non-marginal but contested constituencies that did so, and substantially greater (by an average of thirty-seven points) than the proportion of uncontested constituencies that did so. Furthermore, in all eleven general elections the percentage of marginal constituencies that experienced election violence involving hired roughs was greater (by an average of sixteen points) than the percentage of uncontested constituencies that experienced it. Likewise, in all but two general elections, the percentage of marginal constituencies featuring election violence involving hired roughs was greater (by an average of five points) than the percentage of non-marginal but contested constituencies featuring it. This link between competitiveness, marginality and violence virtually disappears after 1885, but in the prior eleven elections there is robust statistical evidence that violence (both in general and restricted to incidents involving hired roughs) was considerably more likely to occur when elections were contested and most competitive. It bears repeating that we are not arguing that non-strategic electoral violence was entirely absent (hence its continued presence in uncontested and non-marginal seats), but the above correlations suggest that it tended to appear in strategically beneficial contexts.

Having established this strategic link, the natural follow-up question is whether political parties were likely responsible. Our next analysis thus examines the period 1832–80, when double-member constituencies (where each elector had two votes) were the norm, and where numerous historians have taken the number of 'splits' (where a voter cast each vote for a candidate of an opposing party) and 'non-partisan plumps' (where a voter withheld their second vote even though their first vote had been cast for a candidate whose party was fielding another candidate in the constituency) as indicative of the weakness of

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party partisanship in that constituency.[115] Because voter partisanship is likely to be generally barometric of the strength of party organization in a locale, we hypothesize that election violence is likely to be correlated with stronger partisanship and inversely correlated to weaker partisanship. To measure this, we use data from 954 constituency elections in this period. We supplement Cox's vote count data from 882 English and Welsh constituency elections between 1832 and 1880 with data from a further seventy-two constituency elections, located via searches of online newspaper archives. We restrict analysis of split-voting rates to double-member contested constituencies where at least one party fields two candidates and no party fields more than two.[116] We find that, as shown by Figure 6, electoral violence is strongly inversely correlated with both the average split-voting rate (−0.8) and the average non-partisan plumping rate (−0.58). Put differently, as partisan voting behaviour rises, so does electoral violence, and this trend is especially marked from the 1865 election, when two-party mid Victorian politics fully re-emerged after the period of ideological confusion following the fall of Peel. We thus conclude that a sharp rise in party coherency and organizational strength was accompanied by a rise in electoral violence, which, taken alongside our finding that violence tended to occur in strategically optimized contexts, supplies further evidence that the transition from the old Georgian ritual culture to its new party-centric replacement from the 1860s was anything but one of placid sanitization.

This section has argued that a greatly underestimated element of electoral violence was the product of elite strategizing. This conclusion has been sustained by qualitative and quantitative analyses of the role of hired roughs, who were a ubiquitous feature in electioneering throughout the 1832–85 period and were employed for numerous electioneering activities (some of which enjoyed more

[115] See, for example, Gary W. Cox, *The Efficient Secret: The Cabinet and the Development of Political Parties in Victorian England* (Cambridge, 1987); John A. Phillips and Charles Wetherell, 'The Great Reform Act of 1832 and the Political Modernization of England', *American Historical Review*, c, 2 (1995); T. J. Nossiter, *Influence, Opinion and Political Idioms in Reformed England: Case Studies from the North-East* (Brighton, 1975).

[116] See Cox, *Efficient Secret*.

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popular legitimacy than others) by local political elites and their agents. We then demonstrated that roughs were likelier to feature in more explicitly strategic contexts when elections were contested and most competitive, and that it was the newly organized and partisan political parties that were most likely responsible for it.

V
CONCLUSION

This article provides a new account of electoral violence in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries based on systematic qualitative and quantitative analysis of the large textual dataset liberated by the digitization of newspaper archives. Our analysis shows that violence was a substantial feature in every election between the Great Reform Act of 1832 and the election in December 1910, but also uncovers important non-linear patterns in its extent. Violence did not fall after the First Reform Act, but peaked between the Second and Third, then steadily declined in the run-up to the Fourth in 1918. This was a widespread pattern, evident across all regions of England, and in Wales. The article argues that these patterns can only be understood by considering the strategic calculations of political elites and the rise of party organization. This has been demonstrated through an attempt to restore the largely forgotten figure of the hired rough to the dramatis personae of electoral politics, and by demonstrating that election violence was associated with both seat competitiveness and partisan voting. We argue that incidents of electoral violence, especially more severe episodes which often involved roughs, were as likely to indicate the presence of elite control as the absence of control. Moving beyond long-term non-linear patterns, our analysis also demonstrates considerable variation in the extent and nature of violence between elections, and closer analysis of specific examples and cases provides insights into its relationship with the increasing franchise, the secret ballot, the end of the hustings, and party organizational development.

Our findings suggest that scholars have underestimated the role of election violence in British democratization in the long nineteenth century, a story traditionally dominated by franchise extensions, electoral reforms and the growth of political parties. A focus on violence challenges received Whiggish narratives of the 'age of reform' in British political development.

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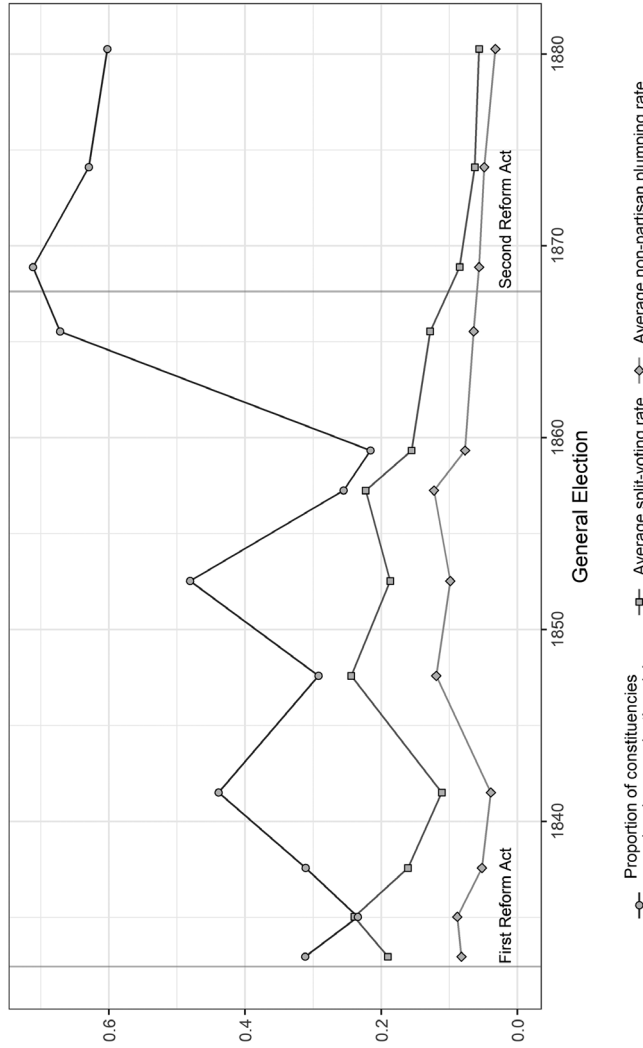
FIGURE 6

TRENDS IN SPLIT VOTING, NON-PARTISAN PLUMPING AND PRE-ELECTION VIOLENCE, 1832–1880



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There was no gradual decline in electoral violence following the First Reform Act. While parliament's passage of working-class enfranchisement in 1867 might have been a triumph of statecraft, it made electoral politics more violent, not less. Similarly, the article challenges cultural explanations that saw electoral violence as a part of election ritual, showing, contrary to O'Gorman and Vernon, that elections in the 1860s saw a rise rather than a fall in violence and, contrary to Lawrence, that the years following 1885 are more notable for its decline rather than for its persistence.

By demonstrating the greatly underestimated role of political strategy this article also questions existing explanations of electoral violence. The (already strongly criticized) view of Richter, Hoppen and Gash that it represented lingering social pathology is rejected as inadequate. Similarly, the reading associated with 'history from below' accounts such as O'Gorman, Vernon and Baer, that elites saw electoral violence as dangerous plebeian protests against exclusion (which required pacification), is also challenged by demonstrating the extent to which they used violence, used it when they were best organized, and used it in strategically advantageous electoral contexts. This is not to say that cultural and ritualized violence did not continue to play an important role right up to the First World War, or that groups of the politically excluded could not use it (as the Suffragettes did in the elections in 1910) against elites. But we can conclude with confidence that the replacement of the old Georgian election rituals with new Victorian successors did not lead to the pacification of electoral culture. On the contrary, the new political men of the dawning age of partisanship and parties were more, not less, likely to use electoral violence precisely because it suited their strategic ends.

More generally, Susan Pedersen astutely observed in 2002 that the shift towards 'political culture' and away from politics (by which she meant statecraft, policy formation, political institutions, leadership, but also psephology and longitudinal quantification) was stimulating an exodus of structural and social-scientific approaches from the discipline.[117] We hope this article gives pause to reflect that this process, which has greatly

[117] Susan Pedersen, 'What Is Political History Now?', in David Cannadine (ed.), *What Is History Now?* (Basingstoke, 2002).

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snowballed since Pedersen's observation two decades ago, may have gone too far, and that politics should remain central to understanding British political history.

One intriguing question posed by this article is why (according to some measures) Britain saw a steep and lasting decline in electoral violence in the Home Rule Crisis election of 1886, rather than in 1885, the first election fought after the Corrupt Practices Act of 1883. This seems at odds with Rix's observation that many constituency associations, especially in better-organized boroughs, had undoubtedly been proactive in their preparations after 1883, tightening their electioneering apparatus and even issuing warnings to sub-agents and workers on how to avoid transgressing the new law.[118] While a thorough investigation is beyond the scope of this article, we suggest that it may have taken an election to be fought in practice under the 'revised rules of engagement' for local parties to acclimatize fully to the uncomfortable new reality that even tiny transgressions by paid agents could now overturn election results. The *East Anglian Daily Times*, reacting to the voiding of the Ipswich election in 1885 (partly on grounds of the illegal employment of 'muscular men' and 'chuckers out'), argued that this harsh precedent would have led to 660 of the 670 constituency results nationwide being invalidated had petitions been lodged against them.[119] Similarly harsh penalizations of the tamest corrupt practice at Norwich and Barrow-in-Furness seem to have prompted an epiphany about the Corrupt Practices Act across the country, with it being described (for example) as 'a Draconian law' (*Bristol Times*), 'purity gone mad' (*Lakes Chronicle*), 'extreme strictness' (*Daily News*) and 'misguided zeal' (*Manchester Times*).[120] This may have been especially true in counties, which saw the bulk of the violence in 1885, and often had the least-developed party organization.

While the Corrupt Practices Act's full effect in curbing electoral violence was only fully realized in 1886, this article clearly amplifies its importance as an agent of change. Naturally, the

[118] Rix, '"Elimination of Corrupt Practices in British Elections"?', 79.

[119] *East Anglian Daily Times*, 3 Apr. 1886.

[120] *Bristol Times and Mirror*, 2 Apr. 1886; *Lakes Chronicle and Reporter*, 2 Apr. 1886; *Daily News*, 3 Apr. 1886; *Manchester Times*, 3 Apr. 1886.

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motivations of parliamentarians who passed an Act that would seemingly harm their own future electoral prospects is intriguing. The standard historical explanation is that the ruinous cost of the 1880 election unleashed a *force majeure* which compelled them to act for financial self-preservation. Recent political-science literature agrees that the increasing costs of traditional, clientelistic electioneering strategies in Britain were key to explaining politicians' willingness to switch away from such tactics.[121] Other explanations which have not been explored by historians might hinge on the dynamics of the parliamentary Liberal Party in 1880, some of whom might have genuinely been inspired by Gladstone's outspoken moral crusade, articulated at Midlothian, where he beseeched his party to act to embody 'right and justice' without favour, mindful that the 'the wealth of the country . . . the rank of the country . . . and the influence that rank and wealth normally bring' were 'arrayed against us'.[122] Even if more cynical calculations predominated, perhaps parliamentary Liberals believed that the comparative electoral impact of passing a zero-tolerance piece of legislation was (at worst) neutral because their opponents would be harmed equally. Further study of the high political motivations for passing the 1883 Act, and for its uncompromising strictness, would shed light on what proved to be a major turning point in the history of British electoral politics.

This study has been made possible both by the mass analysis of datasets liberated by digitization, and by an approach that has leaned heavily on political science, so it seems appropriate to close with some wider methodological reflections.[123] Conscious of earlier quantitative missteps, we advocate for the careful application of quantitative approaches which remain close to the source material and the particularities of individual qualitative cases. Our analysis combines the contextual understanding of case studies with summary statistical patterns, checking each against the other. Building on micro-exemplary quantitative

[121] See, for example, Edwin Camp, Avinash Dixit and Susan Stokes, 'Catalyst or Cause? Legislation and the Demise of Machine Politics in Britain and the United States', *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, xxxix, 4 (2014); Kam and Newson, *Economic Origins of Political Parties*; Mares, *Protecting the Ballot*, ch. 4.

[122] Roy Jenkins, *Gladstone* (London, 1996), 432–3.

[123] See also the Appendix for further methodological detail.

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approaches in demography and prosopography, we believe this is an appropriate means to bring quantitative methods to political history while avoiding the imposition of inappropriately reductive theoretical models to sparse data sources, something of which some quantitative history, including much of the first wave of cliometrics, was undoubtedly guilty.

From this starting point, we think that our findings illustrate some of the contributions which quantitative methods can make to political history more generally. The approach demonstrated here, of creating an overview of a large set of sources and establishing broad trends and associations, provides a means of addressing a vast array of topics and otherwise intractable historical problems. As advances in qualitative historical understanding generate expectations about general patterns, quantitative analysis provides a means of further examining that understanding. This can involve establishing patterns at the general level, as well as assessing whether expected relationships between norms and behaviours are actually observed and whether contemporary rhetoric matched the experienced conditions. The patterns and trajectories that result from quantitative analysis are informative on their own, but can also provide important context, which can lead to the reinterpretation of contemporary qualitative evidence. With vast increases in computational power, and attendant availability of digitized source material, methods like those we propose become much more feasible to implement. It is surely time to reopen the deeper debate about the role of computing in historical research.

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APPENDIX

METHODOLOGY

We performed five analyses to ensure methodological robustness, which help to guard against the inherent shortcomings in our source base of newspapers. These relate to press bias; variation in the volume of news reporting; double-counting; the supposed growing unacceptability of violence after 1867; and separating election violence from 'violence as usual'.

1. *Press bias*. The nineteenth-century political press was often strongly partisan. A report of a crowd pushing at a Tory meeting might be described as harmless boisterousness in a Liberal newspaper but malicious intention to cause physical injury in a Conservative one. Likewise, a judgement on whether a violent incident was the work of hired roughs (implying opposition conniving) or simply over-excitable drunkenness might also vary with the organ's editorial line.

It is first important to point out that newspaper partisanship was far likelier to affect their interpretation of violence (and who was responsible for it) than it was their reporting of the fundamental fact that a violent incident occurred and its core details (where it happened, who was hurt, what was damaged, what was disrupted). To examine this more formally we used the *Mitchell Advertiser* handbooks, which list the partisan affiliation of the vast majority of newspaper titles, for 1847, 1856, 1868, 1885 and 1910.[124] The *Advertiser*'s coverage began in 1847, and we selected these dates for transcription to correspond as closely as possible to general elections. Where possible, we coded a 'partisan leaning' variable to each event in our dataset for the elections nearest these dates, classifying 894 newspaper titles. The key challenge was to match the newspapers reliably to the *Advertiser*'s partisan affiliations over our large dataset. By hand, we looked for matches for publication title, publication location and publication weekday or frequency. This ensured that different newspapers with the same name were matched correctly, and was sensitive to differences in partisan leaning of weekday versus weekend editions of the same publication title and shifts

[124] See Laurel Brake, 'Nineteenth-Century Newspaper Press Directories: The National Gallery of the British Press', *Victorian Periodicals Review*, xlviii, 4 (2015).

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in a title's leaning over time. We successfully matched between 86 and 92 per cent of titles per election, finding (unsurprisingly) that the vast majority had party bias. Roughly 50 per cent of all violent events in our dataset were sourced exclusively from a Liberal or Conservative newspaper. Our full partisanship analysis is available on request. Figure A1 shows that the temporal trend of electoral violence was extremely similar even if we remove all events exclusively evidenced by a report (or reports) from Liberal or Conservative newspapers. Thus, we suggest that, even though newspapers might have supplied quite different political interpretations of electoral violence, their partisanship had little bearing on whether or not a violent event was reported.

2. *Variation in the volume of news reporting*. A second potential problem is that the health of the political press vacillated throughout the 1832–1910 period: there was an explosion in the number of newspaper titles in the late 1850s (stimulated by the removal of stamp and paper duties) but a decline from the mid 1890s.[125] Thus, there is the possibility that fluctuations in reporting electoral violence might simply have mirrored fluctuations in the density of press reporting of election campaigns in general.

To examine this, we began by focusing only on the most severe violence based on the reasonable notion that such events (deaths, riots and disturbances) were significant enough to be reported consistently throughout the period regardless of the prolificity of the press. Figure 2 shows that the overall trendlines for electoral violence, whether measured at the level of incident, riot, disturbance or death, remained similar. In addition, we could also formally check for temporal variation in press density through a separate analysis which took account of the number of unique newspaper titles in our database in each election year. Reassuringly, we found that the Pearson correlation coefficient between annual election violence frequency and annual number of newspaper titles was modest, at 0.35. Finally, if we ran a simulation analysis designed to study how many events per election were recorded assuming the number of newspaper titles

[125] Stephen E. Koss, *The Rise and Fall of the Political Press in Britain*, 2 vols. (London, 1981–4), vol. i, chs. 3, 10.

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was held constant, the overall temporal pattern that emerged was almost identical to Figure 1.[126]

3. *Double*-counting. Naturally, provincial newspapers often reported the same events, sometimes by recycling articles or by including abbreviated versions.[127] For example, a report of an election riot in Leeds from the *Leeds Mercury* might appear identically in other Leeds and South Yorkshire newspapers, and could also survive in an abbreviated form (appearing perhaps a day later) in Birmingham or London papers. This creates the obvious problem that an incident of violence is likely to appear in multiple outlets, potentially across multiple dates, and thus may be counted multiple times unless the events are 'clustered' and each assigned a unique tag. To ensure that each event was only counted once, our research assistant team manually re-reviewed and 'clustered' 20,548 individual reports, identifying 2,971 unique events. There was thus an average of 6.9 articles per unique event identified.

4. *The supposed growing unacceptability of violence after 1867*. It could be argued that increased volumes of reported election violence potentially reflected its new unacceptability after the Second Reform Act. If true, we might expect an increased newspaper focus on electoral violence even while it was in decline, potentially giving a false impression of increased occurrence from 1868. We reject this for three reasons. First, there is no well-supported historiographical claim that the late 1860s witnessed an epiphany on the unacceptability of electoral violence, or political violence in general. Second, we can assume that the most severe events (riots and deaths) would be reported regardless of the unacceptability of violence, and we found that our spike in 1868–85 was sustained even if we simply measured these and excluded less serious violence. Third, if we applied the condition on whether the Riot Act was reported to have been read at an event, newspapers' proclivity to label an event a 'riot' did not appear to have markedly increased. During 1832–65,

[126] Full details of this test's sampling procedure, and its results, are available from the authors by request.

[127] The Scissors and Paste Project (featuring the Scissors-and-Paste-o-Meter) has been created to help scholars deal with the issue of reprints and reuses across multiple digitized newspaper databases: <https://osf.io/nm2rq> (accessed 18 May 2024).

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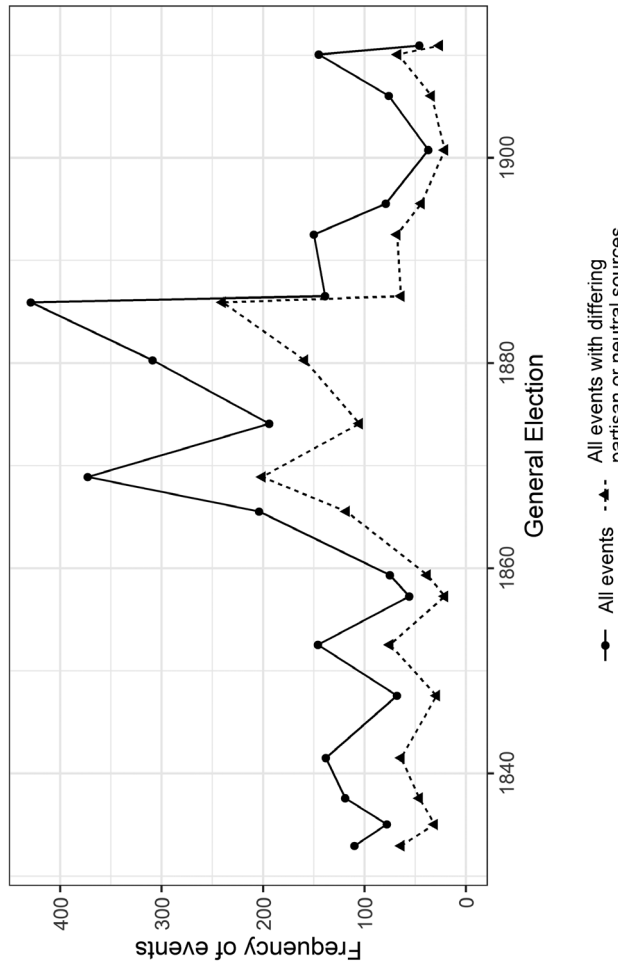
FIGURE A1

CONTROLLING FOR PRESS BIAS IN REPORTING ELECTORAL VIOLENCE, 1832–1910



The dashed line shows the trendline including only events reported by both the Liberal press and the Conservative press.

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98 per cent of events where the Riot Act is reported by at least one newspaper to have been read are also described as a 'riot' by at least one report, and this percentage increases very slightly to 99 per cent during 1868–85. During 1832–65, 34 per cent of events where the Riot Act is not reported to have been read are also described as a 'riot' by at least one report, and this percentage increases very slightly to 35 per cent during 1868–85. If a new moral climate of greater sensitivity to violence had been born, one might have expected newspapers to lower their threshold for employing a potentially sensationalist term like 'riot' to describe a violent event.

5. *Separating election violence from 'violence as usual'*. This problem stems from the obvious possibility that election campaigns simply reflected a basal societal level of violence in Victorian Britain and were more typical than they were exceptional.[128] While there are no reliable measures of actual levels of violence outside election periods, we addressed this concern by showing that newspapers reported more violence during election campaigns than outside them. Specifically, we showed that articles in the British Newspaper Archive (BNA) containing words associated with violence ('mob', 'riot', 'disturbance' and 'rough') were more frequent during election periods. Table A1 shows the ratio of these articles relative to articles containing other common words (like a Google Ngram, this adjusts for the changing size of the BNA).[129] We calculated this measure daily for 1832 to 1910. Specifically, Table A1 compares the incidence of each 'violent word' in the thirty-day period around each election with the average incidence on all other days. For example, our results for the word 'mob' indicated a ratio of about six articles per hundred outside elections, but nine per hundred during them. 'Riot', 'disturbance' and 'rough' also occurred at an elevated rate

[128] For example, J. Carter Wood, *Violence and Crime in Nineteenth-Century England: The Shadow of our Refinement* (London, 2004), does not note elections as events in which public violence was more common or acceptable.

[129] These common words are 'he', 'she', 'its', 'what', 'which', 'because' and 'can'. These words are common enough to appear extremely frequently while still being indexed by the BNA (that is, they are not so common as to be treated as a 'stop word').

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TABLE A1

RATE OF OCCURRENCE OF ARTICLES CONTAINING TERMS ASSOCIATED WITH VIOLENCE (RELATIVE TO COMMON WORDS) DURING ELECTIONS AND OUTSIDE ELECTION PERIODS, 1832–1910

Term	**Non-election incidence**	**Election incidence**	***t*-value**	***p*-value**
Disturbance	0.108	0.118	−6.0	<.001
Mob	0.061	0.088	−17.5	<.001
Riot	0.065	0.092	−12.6	<.001
Rough	0.083	0.087	−4.6	<.001

during election periods, and these differences were all highly statistically significant. This sharp increase of discussion of violence in the local and national press during election campaigns increased our confidence that electoral violence was not simply 'violence as usual'.

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